Memoirs
of the late

Aron Jacob Perkel

o.b.m.

1882 - 1975

Translated from the handwritten Hebrew
by his youngest son, Jonah Perkel

The Yartzeit for my father is in the month Tevet, 23rd, and for my mother, the same month, the 25th.

This is being written in the evening in the month of Kislev, in the year Tarza (1930).

I was born in Adamov, Siedlec Gouvernia, in Poland, in the year Tarmag (1882) in the new month of Elul. I was married on Saturday evening, 21 Adar, in the year Tarsaz (1907) in Warsaw.

Zahavah was born on Saturday, 29 Shvat, Tarsag (1908).

Avraham was born in the month of Chesvan in the year Tarav, on Sunday (1911).

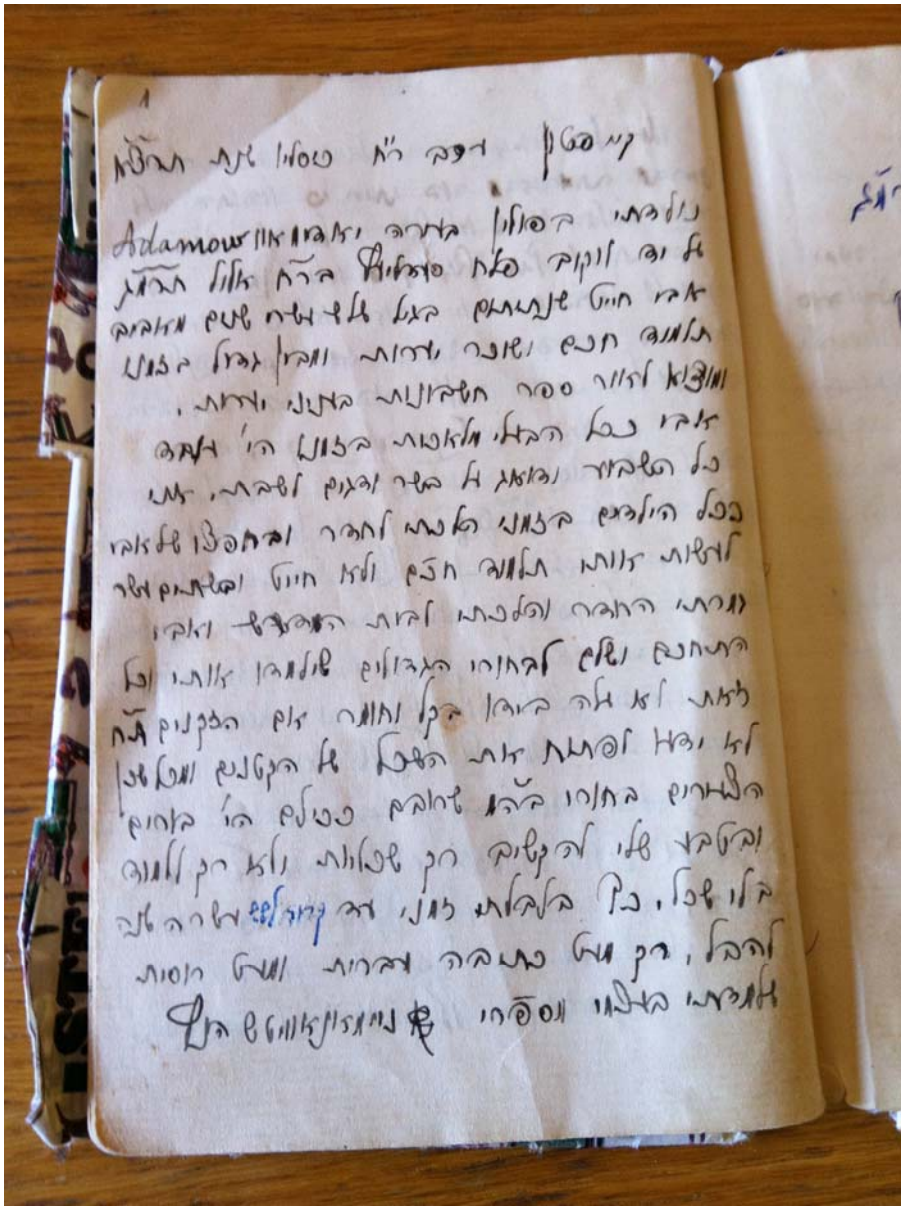
Haya was born on Thursday, 11 Menachem Av, Tarvag (1913).

Nathan was born on Saturday, 4 Adar in the year Tar-ag (1918).

Moshe was born on Friday in the month Shvat (Saturday) in the year Tarpav (1922).

They were all born in Warsaw.

Jonah was born in Tel Aviv on Wednesday, 1 Tamuz, Tarpad (1924).



First page of the original
hand-written memoirs of Aron Jacob

The heading at the top of the page reads:
Cape Town, Erev Rosh Chodesh Kislev [5]691

Cape Town - beginning of the month of Kislev, Tartza (1930)

I was born in Poland in a village called Adamov near Lukov, which is part of Sedlitz, in the month of Elul, Tarmag. My father was a tailor who was orphaned when he was 13 years old. His father, who was a highly intellectual personality for his time and a timber merchant, had a wide general knowledge and had actually published a book on accounting relating to forestry.

My father, like all tradesmen of the time, worked the whole week only to worry about (being able to provide) meat and fish for Shabbat. I, like all the children of my time, went to Cheder as it was my father's wish to make me a Talmud Chochem too, and not a tailor. At the age of 12 I finished Cheder (Hebrew school) and went to a school of higher learning, Beth Hamidrash, and my father then thought better and decided to pay some of the more advanced students to teach me as it was difficult for the older generation to deal with the young generation and open their minds as they were mostly coming from homes of illiteracy which was fortunately not the same with me whose nature it was to attend diligently and not only to memorise. This, unfortunately, caused me to waste my time until I reached the age of 16 and managed to learn a bit of Hebrew writing and a bit of Russian which, in effect, I learnt myself from the books of Naiminowitz, Hans. More than this my father could not manage and in this way all his efforts were wasted, because I remained with no progress, with no knowledge of the Talmud and not even the meaning of the words, not even simple manners of how to behave, and no discipline or how to get on with people.

I returned to the small town where there were 150 families. I decided, together with my parents, to learn a trade and in this time there was nothing except tailors and shoemakers which, at that stage, was a lowly trade. We then decided to go to Warsaw and in the month of Sivan, Shvat Tarat, my father and I travelled to Warsaw and he apprenticed me to a watchmaker in a suburb of Warsaw, who was a very religious Chassid and a neighbour of Rabbi Olamas, the grandson of Rabbi Kastzk, to teach me for 25 rouble, and it was for me to pay a further amount of 5 rouble each month for board. That would be for 18 months and the whole cost would therefore be 90 rouble, so in total sum would have been 115 rouble that my father would have to pay over a period and this was agreed on in writing and he immediately paid 5 rouble.

The time passed without any further money being paid because where would my

father have got so much money when he could not even find food for his own house for Shabbat. The man I was working for was afraid to send me back home, but at the same time did not want to teach me the trade until he was paid a further 5 rouble. After six months, and the expenses consuming all the funds that he had received from my father which were the funds that my principal had received from my father for the food and the teaching, all that was left was 10 rouble. Until that day all he received in total was 10 rouble for the food and the teaching, but he did not do it in a fair or honest way because he earned quite a lot of income from my labour, as I completed all the assignments that I was given in the repair situation.

I loved my work and I worked with a total devotion because I saw opportunities and also that I could apply my talents. I was able to work very fast, and the speed of my work matched that of the more experienced tradesmen who had been there for many years. After three months I knew more than even my employer who was the watchmaker. I was also, by nature, a very attentive young man who could apply my mind to everything, and it was here that I realised that it is important for a person to educate himself and know a lot, but to my disappointment I realised that I had actually learnt nothing, and I am so far away from the big towns and the people of such big towns. I was even afraid to talk because I thought that everybody else knew much more than I did and I remained, as it is written "my soul is like the dust to all". It was my nature to despise vain people who indulge in foolishness in thought and deed and wish to remain simpletons. Therefore I walked from the watchmaker's house to the synagogue every morning, and on the Sabbath I spent almost the whole day in the synagogue of the Rabbi who was the neighbour of my employer, and at infrequent intervals I used to go to my uncle Leibel who lived in Warsaw and, as the saying goes, I found him unfortunately very shallow in knowledge as there was much to learn and understand.

I began to learn by myself every Saturday, studying the Bible and Talmud and other books, and these Saturdays gave me much more than the years that had passed. With all this I still did not overlook my religious observance - in fact quite the opposite - in this place I associated with Chassidim who came from the cities to the Rabbi, and all the festivals I travelled back home and after the festivals I remained in the town a few extra days and repaired watches as there was no other watchmaker. From this I obviously earned some income and earned respect from everybody. I had been to Warsaw and had succeeded.

I wore a Capota and I was able to speak Russian, and I could earn my own money, that is to say, I seem to have surpassed my former friends. I therefore finished my

apprenticeship (18 months) in Succoth, Tarsay. I returned home and did not return to this place, remaining in Adamov. I bought myself a few tools. From the whole area Jews and non-Jews brought me watches to repair. I also bought some merchandise for re-sale, and so I repaired as well as sold goods and became a respected merchant, and I felt that I brought honour to my parents as well, as I was no longer the fearful and shy person I had been and sometimes I mixed with doctors and the priest and generally more intellectual people.

I spoke Polish and Russian with everybody, even with the Station Master and so on, but despite all this I could not settle in the small town as it had no appeal to me. I had no feeling for the place. (There was) not even one young girl from all those that the matchmakers tried to introduce me to. I had also managed to finish the work available in the area quite quickly and successfully, and the work therefore diminished.

After Pesach, therefore, I returned to Warsaw. I lodged and boarded with my uncle and I found work immediately not far from my uncle's house, where I worked until Shavuot, and then I returned home at the request of my parents.

When I returned from the festival I found another person working in my place. I looked for a job for over a month and I could not find anything, even where a worker was needed, and I could not understand why until I discovered that it was because of my Capota and my galoshen and going without a collar. I was looked upon as a Yeshiva Bocher and a Batlan - an idler and one who could not apply himself to hard work but relied on charity. I did not want to wear a collar and tie, and I was scared to put these on because in Yadamov this was considered a great transgression - also in Warsawwith the Chassidim - and no matter how much my uncle and auntie and cousins tried to influence me that it is not such a great sin, and that there would still be a place for me in Heaven even if I would put on a collar and tie, they could not persuade me with all their talking because I was simply afraid.

However, in the end I did succumb because I had nothing to eat, so I dressed up with a collar and jacket and almost immediately found work in Basel Street with some drunkard. I worked with him for two months and he did not pay me until I found work with new watchmakers. I worked for about one month for three roubles a week which, of course, I was not happy with because it was the same stereotyped work with no change, like in a factory.

I eventually found work in a shop owned by Kalman Rootstein in Nalvechi Street 47, for 4 rouble a week, and this, of course, gave me great satisfaction because it was an honour to be working in Nalvechi Street as quite often we got work from various acquaintances, and I worked here till Succoth, the year Tarsad (1904). I managed to feed

and clothe myself and even had some money to give to my father, and simultaneously with this I gained tremendous experience in various kinds of watches and jewellery and also learned the business. I read a lot of books and I also learned a lot spiritually on morals, which I have to this day.

After Succoth I went to work again in a watchmaking factory because my present boss could not give me more than four roubles a week, and in the factory they gave me five roubles a week. Here I mixed with non-religious workers and sometimes we had arguments, as at that stage I was very ignorant of atheism. In the month of Shvat the Russian Japanese war broke out and, like all beginnings of war, nobody knew what was going to happen. Work stopped, and in the month of Adar I returned home to Adamov because I already began to understand the daily news and in Adamov there was nothing. I brought the newspaper called "My Friend" from Petersburg, and from this we knew all the latest news of the war and what was happening around the world.

After Pesach I pretended to be crippled with one leg shorter than the other, in order to avoid becoming a soldier during the war, because after Succoth in the year Tarsad I became eligible for conscription as a soldier. For 25 roubles I was able to make myself a cripple, and until today I continue to limp, but only voluntarily. Because my parents did not get a birth certificate for me according to the legal requirements, they called me to the Government offices in the city of Lukov, in the middle of summer, to verify my age, and they judged me to be 19 years old, and therefore I was to join the army within the next two years. I was able to improve my limp and now, all of a sudden, everybody began to shower me with prospective brides from the whole area. I had no intention of going to Warsaw and I was not even sure I would obtain work.

Immediately after Succoth, Tarsah, in the middle of the war, the Revolution started and there were pogroms in Warsaw and all the big cities in Russia and, naturally, my parents were reluctant to let me stay in Warsaw. However, I did take a shop in the middle of the town, I bought new and second hand merchandise at a Mr. Leiblish Lisselake that was valueless because all the time that I worked there I could not sell a single watch, because who would buy a watch that does not go? I also had chain watches and pocket watches which I had in stock. However, I even began to repair sewing machines and everybody called me the "Professor Merchant".

I became, so to speak, well-known and the matchmaking multiplied from all over the place. If it were not for my father being a tailor I could have married into a Chassidic family like the daughter of a Rabbi or a daughter of a respected Chassid, and despite all that I had some very distinguished offers without nadan (dowry) and the rest of them were not even good-looking. Even my parents thought in terms of honour.

However, I had already made up my mind what I wanted and I would not allow to happen to me what happened to my friends, whose parents arranged the matchmaking without the bride and groom even knowing each other, and so the days of the winter passed and the summer, and at the end of summer an opportunity arose to take the shop of Kalman Rootstein in Warsaw.

I did not have any money, and the Revolution became more intense and despite this my father wanted to buy the shop for me, and to borrow 200 rouble to pay Rootstein for the goodwill. This was an excellent idea because with a shop one could make a really good shidach and become prosperous, and one could receive quite a lot of money without any problems. Havayit, a friend of my father, wanted to lend me the 200 roubles but there were obstacles in the way, the revolution. We tried all kinds of ideas until we realised that we should consult the Rabbi from Lukov, the grandson of the great Rabbi from Kotzk. My father and I then travelled through to Lukov in one day where we consulted the Rabbi, and we decided to abandon the idea of taking the shop because of the revolution and I would also have to be alone in Warsaw, and this made no sense in any circumstances. We therefore abandoned the idea, and in fact the revolution intensified with such ferocity that windows of homes were broken and killing became the order of the day. They killed many of the Russian people.

In the same winter I was in Warsaw for a bit of business and my uncle Leibel and my auntie presented me with a new match. I saw that she was a beautiful girl, and therefore I had no further intention of asking for nadan, and whatever I got I would be happy with.

I returned home and in the month of Adar, Tarsan, to the engagement of my cousin Dvorah. My parents travelled to her wedding and at this wedding we arranged for my engagement to Tovah Sheindel. I was promised 250 rouble dowry and one year's free board and lodging. My parents came and brought me the engagement conditions with Mazal Toy and sent me the Shabbat Purim to my future mother and father-in-law. They gave me 10 gold roubles as a present, and with this, obviously, I bought presents for my bride. After Purim we were married in a town known as Kotzk. We drove together and after the wedding we drove through Adamov.

Now again the question arose about the shop of Rootstein's. We finalised the discussion with the Rabbi and we travelled together to Lukob by train because this was the way of travelling. We all travelled, including my father. I was left, however, alone to continue getting the Rabbi's advice and after bargaining over the price for the shop, we agreed to buy the shop because now I had some money, and on the same day I came to buy the shop, but in a manner Rootstein remained a partner, having a quarter share, till

after the call-up to the army. In the meantime he took 150 rouble and after that it was for me to pay a further 50 roubles and then he would leave the partnership.

For Pesach I travelled again to my parents' home in Adamov. I sold the whole shop together with the watches in Adamov and immediately after the holiday I returned to Warsaw because my little brother, Moshe Tzvi, reached the period of becoming a tradesman and I also needed a young fellow as an assistant. My parents left Adamov and came with all the children to settle in Warsaw a month after Pesach. They took a flatlet in Mila Street no. 7, not far from me. I took my young brother into the shop as he had no other worries except for food, and he appeared to be very good. I also gave our parents three rouble a week.

During the summer the revolution became very severe and tense, and every day there were killings from both sides. Bombs were thrown by the revolutionaries until the winter of the year of Tarsaz, when it started to quieten down a little. Now again my call-up was imminent, whereas up to now I was fortunate that my shorter leg allowed me to be exempted from the army. Many people, apparently, allowed their legs to be shortened and even then it appears this procedure did not ensure exemption from the army. We thought of other ways. I travelled to Lukov with my handicap and there was a doctor there, Jacob Niskis, a specialist in other physical deformities. We made an arrangement between us that I give him 25 roubles to do something with my throat that year before the festivals but I had to be with him for at least a week to be examined, and he would then operate on me. I gave him 5 roubles deposit and arranged to go to him after Succoth, as the short leg was not sufficient for the purpose. In the meantime my father heard about the throat problem, that it could even cause death because a few had already died from this operation, and therefore this was not a good idea. My father went to the Rabbi of Lukob to find out what to do and came back with the answer from the Rabbi not to undertake the new procedure of the throat, but to remain with what we had done before. We left the money and finished.

After Succoth, the year Tarsaz, I came to Lukov, the town where one had to enlist, and I was allocated high number, and until they came to my number it took two weeks. In the meantime we had a discussion with the army and with the doctors and I paid 200 rouble (my nadan). Through this procedure I again freed myself from the army, another doctor got 100 rouble and some other people also got money. I was therefore left in freedom, but without money. I sent two telegrams, one to my mother and one to my bride.

Now there was great joy. My father and I came home for Saturday and made it a festive day - a thanksgiving meal - because at that point in time I was now 100% with

my body and limbs and others had become blind, lame, deaf, without fingers and all kinds of other things, and I only had a slight problem.

After a short while we came again to talk about the wedding but I had no money and I still had to pay Kalman Rootstein 50 rouble, and how could I now carry the burden and still have a partner in my workshop. I asked my father-in-law to give me a further 100 rouble for the "kest" (dowry) which he promised to give me for a year, and I was also not in a good position because of the 100 rouble, and it would be difficult for me as a result of the marriage. After a lot of discussions and bargaining that took a few months, he (my father-in-law) agreed to give me 50 rouble to pay Kalman Rootstein, which I gave him, and he left the partnership.

On 21 Adar, in the year Tarsag, at the end of the holy Sabbath, we then had the wedding, and I stayed in my father-in-law's house until after Pesach, when I rented my own flatlet for the first time in Noluki Street 43, 4th floor. We remained next to the family and near the shop for 7 roubles a month, and the shop cost me 16 roubles a month for rent, so that means I gave about 23 roubles a month for rent. That is without a living and debts that I had after the wedding of approximately 200 roubles, and the shop was empty and had no goods to sell, only labour, but despite all that I had no worries because I had a living from the work and also, slowly, slowly I managed to pay my debts and also buy merchandise little by little, and so the year went by and my first daughter Zahavah was born, on 29 Shvat, the year Tarsag. My wife, may she rest in peace, preferred the shop to the house and therefore she asked her own grandmother, an old woman and a good woman, to look after the child and she would not leave the shop.

After Pesach of the year Tarsat I left the flat at Nalochi Street 43 and went to stay with my parents in Nalochi Street no. 7, and there my daughter Liebe Friemd was born (also may she rest in peace) in the month of Sivan, Tarsat, and a short while later my father hired a flat in Desialna Street no. 10. We stayed there a few months until I myself hired a flat in the same house where the shop was, from a family that had two small rooms for 12 rouble a month.

My wife, may she rest in peace, was my right-hand person and every year she renovated the shop with new carpets. She knew merchandise and how to sell and buy much more than I did because I was obliged to work and she, may she rest in peace, looked after me and ensured that we had the best of food and nothing was too much for her. She deprived herself in order to make sure that I had, to honour me and to be proud of me, even more than a mother. She just ate what was available but made sure that I had the choicest of foods. I did not even know how to be grateful and to be aware that I had such a wonderful woman, even more than goodness, and so the time went by, and

after two and a half years my son, Abraham, was born, in the month of Chesvan, the year Taray.

The summer of that year the family left the big appartment and I took it for 20 rouble a month. At the same time my grandmother Sarah, the mother of my mother, was with me as well. In the month of Menachen Av, the year Tarag, my daughter Haya was born in the winter.

In the winter of the year Tar'az I went out of the shop because the landlord of the house in Nalechi Street 47 was renovating the shops and therefore I was obliged to leave the shop for about three months, which was finished on the evening of Purim. When I took the shop back, a very beautiful shop with electricity, I had lost a lot during the three months. I had to pay bills, and afterwards I needed new and pretty merchandise for the new shop, and this I could not get with bills, and also the rental doubled now to 30 roubles a month. The burden was very heavy as I had to lay out about 200 roubles for the shop as well. The time was certainly very depressing until 9th Av in the year Tarad when the great war broke out.

We were obliged not to pay any further bills and also not even rent, that was the law. It was a moratorium that the Russian government pays and that gave me relief on one hand, but on the other hand business also stopped.

In the first two months I had absolutely no business and no livelihood and despite that I had relief from the debts and the expenses and the bills until the year Tar'ah.

The business began to improve because all the soldiers began to buy watches, chains, rings, and also brought work in. The position certainly brightened amongst all the watchmakers and also in other types of businesses because there were many soldiers in Poland at the time, especially in Warsaw and especially as I purchased the merchandise for cash and I bought it inexpensively, and therefore I began to have money and also merchandise, with good profits and little expenses because we were not obliged to pay rent. Also, all the bills remained with the merchants and we kept the money. I even began to change money, marks, roubles, any kind, and the roubles became small change when it came to doing business and it was good, very good, the whole winter.

On the first day of Pesach, the year Tar'ah, my daughter Bracha, may she rest in peace, was born. I had very good earnings till the month of Av when the Russians left Poland and the Prussians came in their stead. The whole position changed and blew up in my face, and all our good hopes about the coming of the Prussians and all the joy in their coming, to become free again from the Kossaks and the Russian soldiers who created terror and fear in all the Jewish villages, became a great mourning period. It is

true we became free men, even from the Russians and from the murderous Poles - we we were free even from the problems of business.

Business suddenly stopped and even though we were free we also had "freedom" from food, as there was nothing to eat. The authorities closed the "gate" and bread went up ten times from the previous prices, meat was totally unavailable and what food was available went up from ten to twenty times and more. During the winter we sat in the dark without coal, and inflation soared to impossible heights and earnings became less and less. Times were very difficult and people began to run away to the fields because there you could get bread reasonably and I, too, hired a wagon because we were not allowed to travel by train, and I sent my wife, may she rest in peace, with five children, on the evening of Purim, the year Tar'av, to Adamov, the town where I was born.

We travelled up to a town called Zelishkov, from there to Adamov with another wagon, and after two days and two nights of strenuous travel we came to Adamov. With the train from Warsaw to Adamov it took five hours. We travelled on the festival of Pesach, after many problems with the Prussian officials of the government. I obtained permission to travel with the train and in this way I closed my shop and after cleaning the house for Pesach I left Warsaw with the train, and in the morning we waited for a second train in the town of Lukob and, while waiting for the second train, a Christian Pollak gave me a severe blow on the nose and I began bleeding profusely. I called on a Prussian to help me but it was in vain and I continued to travel to Adamov. The blow was so severe that they did not even recognise me when I reached home. After Pesach I returned to Warsaw and gave up the large flat, and I only rented one room next to the family in the same house, only for myself, with one bed and one clothing cupboard. The summer was very difficult and life seemed worthless.

In the festival of Shavuot I again travelled to Adamov and I began to think in terms of totally vacating the shop because there was nothing to do and I had no alternative. On the Sabbath of Nachamu my wife, may she rest in peace, came with my son Avraham who was dangerously sick with the lungs, almost like scarlet fever, and I saw in my wife's expression, may she rest in peace, that she did not want to return to Adamov. I immediately rented another flat in Nelikotz Street, two rooms with a kitchen with all the conveniences, for 20 roubles a month, and with a veranda, half the price of my previous rental of 37 roubles, besides the money was worthless. That is why my flat was so cheap. For three months I paid 60 roubles and for the caretaker another 10 roubles, altogether 70 roubles. I asked for a cheaper flat so the caretaker, in a joke, said that "You are, in fact, buying the rooms with 60 roubles and you won't pay so quickly in any case" and so it was. After three months he did not even ask me for more money because

nobody paid their rent.

I brought all the children from Adamov, also some household utensils, and of the neighbours that were in that same house, all thought me mad, why he took a new flat with all the conveniences as everbody simply saw death in front of them with starvation at the same time. The winter of Tar'az the problems became even worse with a biting winter as though it came from the skies and there was nothing with which to warm the house and no food. The bread that one could obtain was not even clean bread, mixed with all kinds of ingredients that our fathers and grandfathers had never witnessed and rationed to a miserly half-pound to each person for a day, and which not everybody had money with which to buy.

Many people fell in the streets of Warsaw from starvation and the cold and so the winter dragged on until the year Tar'ach, when typhus suddenly broke out (erupted) and many people just fell dying. In the same winter, on the 10th Shvat, the year Tar'ach, my father-in-law Nathan Joseph, may he rest in peace, died, and on the 4th of the month of Adar, the year Tar'ach, my son Nathan Joseph was born, who was named after his grandfather. The winter was again extremely tough, severe and there were those who managed to accustom themselves to this kind of life, and there were others who could not adjust themselves to this kind of life and simply fell 111 and died, and those that did not die immediately, died later.

My daughter Liebe Friend fell ill with some stomach ailment and I sent her to Adamov in the summer. She was there a few months and in the winter Tar'at she fell ill, very severely, and was bedridden in the middle of winter, and after three months of this illness dragging on, and after many doctors with many kinds of medicines and exhorbitant expenses, she died on the last day of Pesach, the year Tar'at.

During that period we apparently did not seem to have applied our minds to the girl Bracha who fell so seriously ill from the cold, and two days after the funeral of Liebe Friemd, may she rest in peace, was the funeral of Bracha, may she rest in peace.

In the month of Sivan my son, Pinchas, was born, may he also rest in peace.

In the beginning of winter in the year Tar-af, the British coalition overwhelmed the Prussians, and the Prussians fled from all the places they had occupied and also from Poland. We lost all the strength to withstand all these difficult tests, and we did not know what the next day would bring.

Because we were not accustomed, like before, to look at Satan straight in the face, we were unable to live for fear of the cruel Poles. Even then we slowly got used to them also, to the power of the Poles, and slowly business did begin again. I began to earn once again.

Various merchants arrived from America and from other countries to buy gold and silver and gemstones because they knew that in Poland there was a great recession and everything was very cheap. Many people left to go to the United States via Poland from Russia, Latvia and various other lands, and everybody had to pass through Warsaw where the consul was, to buy the shipping tickets and therefore many, almost all of them, had to sit and wait in Warsaw until they could travel, and so the business improved and so did the work from all sides, and when they left the country they left all their money in Warsaw. With their money they purchased various articles, watches, gold, silver, gemstones and also expensive winter clothes.

Business improved considerably, and in the year Tar-pa I threw up the work of the watch repair section because I became envious of those who had no ability to work but were progressing much more speedily than I, and therefore I left the work and began doing business (selling) only, which helped me tremendously as the time was more suitable for this type of work because those people were not fully aware of what "devaluation" means. To give an example, they did not understand that 100 rouble of today is much cheaper than 100 rouble from before. They only knew that silver and gold and valuable articles had gone up in price by tremendous amounts and therefore each person who possessed any valuable article sold it and got a tremendous amount of roubles or marks.

Therefore the business in valuable articles was much better than anything else, and we also shared in this business "boom". I had a very good winter season without the workshop until before Pesach, the year Tar-pah, and then the government of Poland was giving permission to go through their borders to America, and generally emigration from Russia stopped. With this, unfortunately, business also stopped, because we purchased not for ourselves as stock but for the travellers who paid good prices, and now there was nobody to sell to, so we, too, stopped buying, and therefore another crisis came up, and at that time the "shofar" began to blow again and I also became sick of the life in Poland, and I therefore began to think in terms of travelling to Eretz Israel.

I sold my shop and my flat and received very little money for them to last us until we decided to travel, and the balance on the ticket, and as it was, there were riots in Jerusalem and therefore permits to go to Israel also stopped. Because of that I was not able to sell my shop or my flat, so I gave back the money that I had been paid, and in that winter I had an infection in my ear which needed an operation, and after Pesach I could not travel any more and I had no work yet, and there was no income.

I rented for my family a flat in a village called Attask, near the Madzichen station, on a monthly basis, and during the summer I lived there till the Sabbath of Nachamu,

and every Sabbath I travelled there because my brother Moshe was in the shop, until one day the child Pinchas got very ill, may he rest in peace. I came back to the town with all the children because he needed medical attention, and he became sick again, and as the days went by the illness became very severe until he needed an operation on his left side, and they cut open two of his bones and they seem to have healed him for some three months until the winter of the year Tar-pay, and then he again fell seriously ill with an illness called measles, and because he had an open wound in his side, the lungs were overwhelmed and he died in the month Chesvan, the year Tar-pay.

On the sixth day of Shvat, of the year Tar-pay, on Saturday, my son Morris was born, and during the summer once again I hired a flat in Ottesk Street in a place called Mirzin. I had a good living and I improved myself considerably amongst my contemporaries and I also commenced my studies again amongst my friends because I lived with the Rabbi Dapillion, may he rest in peace, in one house, amongst the Chassidim. At the same time the Rabbi from Lukov passed away and I became very religious (a Chassid) amongst all these intellectuals because I earned well and I subscribed to the Kiddush and entertained with tea every Saturday at my place, and also Malaya Malka which my wife, may she rest in peace, who was a wonderful person, prepared with good grace, especially for all the poor Chassidim. Because of all that, my name became well-known and her's likewise.

With this, my earning capacity improved and great honour and joy became part of our lives, and so the time went by in goodness and joyfulness through the winter of the year Tar-pak, and once again the shofar began to blow over Israel, and again my thinking was to travel to Israel.

At that stage I had money, and I clearly foresaw what Poland was going to be like and that it was our duty to leave. My wife, may she rest in peace, agreed with me that I should travel. I travelled by myself with a bit of stock of varied articles and after Shavuot in the year Tar-pag I travelled with Chalutzim and Chalutzot to Israel, and for the first time I saw what the world is like, because I travelled via Lemburg, from Lemburg to Rumania until Constantinople - five days we travelled in the train. We remained in Constantinople on the ship "Romania" that travelled during that time, and we travelled through Turkey on the Bosphorus, Dardanelles and the Marmer Sea from Friday, 4 p.m. till Wednesday morning when we arrived at Haifa, where I disembarked, and for the first time set foot on Eretz Israel.

In the beginning I was afraid to go outside as I had not seen any town or city other than Warsaw, and because of that I was afraid of every person I saw until I became used to it, and then I began to display my goods to various watchmakers, and I sold for a few

pounds with a very good profit. I was in Haifa for eight days and I travelled to Jaffa and to Tel Aviv where I met acquaintances in the watchmaking fraternity and here I sold more than in Haifa. I therefore had very little left other than leather goods.

In Tel Aviv there was a very slight recession, and they began lighting Tel Aviv with electricity. It was more than 80% in Nachlat Benyamin, Herzel Street, Allenby Street and all the suburbs in Tel Aviv - there was no real business centre. I was in Tel Aviv and Jaffa for ten days and then I travelled to Jerusalem, and here it was like being in my own home as I was with Rabbie Samuel Tul and Raefel Tourman, and Isaac, the son of the Rabbi. I sold all my stock and I had 60 pounds of a variety of stock, and I sold it with a good profit of more than 20 pounds. During that time I visited the cave of Machpella in Hebron.

I was also in Jerusalem for three weeks. I saw almost the whole of Israel. I also went to Bnei Brak. There was absolutely no directional sign as to where Bnei Brak was, and after seven weeks I travelled through Jaffa in the same ship, Romania, back to Poland, and in Shabbat Nahamu in the year Tarpaz, I returned home.

I found my shop full of new stock and much more attractive than when I left, and my whole household was much improved. Then I realised what kind of a wife I had, who could do so much in so little time - one in a thousand. I also brought them money in dollars from the stock I had sold.

Many people then came to me to enquire about Israel and I enjoyed giving everyone answers, and everybody wanted to know what my opinion and outlook was as to what to do, and in my opinion it was only to travel with as much money as we could - not less than, at least, 1 000 pounds - and because I did not have so much money I left my thinking about going to Israel in abeyance because Poland suddenly improved as well. Business became brisk with excellent earnings and came with honour and "parnosse", and I saw that in Israel this would take a long time to achieve. I therefore remained in Poland, in Lubow, till the winter of the year Tar-pat, during the Karbaski regime and with this, also, the earning capacity diminished, and Karbaski started to take from each person who had anything to give up. Then once again I began to think in terms of leaving Poland, and I began to pay more attention to this matter to enable me to plan to leave Poland.

Again I sold my shop for 1 300 dollars and I got for myself 800 dollars, and the owner of the shop got 230 dollars. I sold my flat but only got 400 dollars for it from the owner for his grandson. If it had not been for that I would have got 800 dollars. I sold my stock, which I did not think was needed, and I bought other stock that one could trade and also inexpensive, because in Warsaw there was then a crisis and I bought very

valuable gemstones and pearls and 100 wristwatches, gilded, and about 300 nickel ones and ordinary ones. I also bought a standing clock that I had in my house, which I intended to take to Israel. I sold everything including my clothing cupboard with a mirror, which I sold for 120 dollars. I also sold my overcoat for 80 dollars and my wife's coat for 70 dollars, and I took with me the standing clock and various household goods, and I paid 200 dollars for two passports.

I left Warsaw with all my family and again travelled through Rumania and Turkey. There were approximately 300 families travelling together with us, also Isaac Grashtnikor with all his small children. We arrived at Jaffa on the fifth day of the month of Sivan, and were there for two days until after Shavuot, in Malon Varshayski, which was then on the beach. I immediately rented a room in the centre of the business section in the house of Dubkin, who had a big home and sold it. A short while later I purchased the house, a wardrobe and various other household things. I began to display my goods.

Merchants came to my house. I sold pearls for a profit of some ten pounds and various other goods and I was very content and my wife, may she rest in peace, was at my side and she was also very happy and overwhelmed.

In the second week I was there I bought a piece of land for 130 pounds and my wife, may she rest in peace, was in her eighth month with Jonah. She was not feeling so well and therefore did not go to the market the whole week for any purchases, but sent Zahava to buy, but on that day she went herself to prepare for the Shabbath. In the third week I completed the purchase of the land and I went with her to show her the piece of land, and she was very satisfied. She gave me her plans for building on the plot and we sought the best advice, and I walked as though I was dancing. However, the Holy Spirit must have said "You are overjoyed at a time when everybody else feels depressed and down", and I could not foresee what he had in store for me.

On the Sabbath when I came back from the synagogue I got a message that my wife, may she rest in peace, was extremely sick and could not even get out of bed, and in spite of that she still got up and ate the Shabbat meal with me and immediately fell back into bed after the meal.

I did not place too much importance on this because almost everybody who had come from overseas was ill. Many managed to overcome their illness but many were still ill. It appears that this is normal for people who change their surroundings, especially from a point of view of atmosphere and cold as from Poland to Israel. They seemed to get a fever and after a short while, seemed to be recovered. Nevertheless, on Sunday when I saw that she had a temperature of 39 degrees, I called a doctor and he indicated that she had a weak heart and I was absolutely astounded because up to that

point she had a very strong heart and she had never even had pain, and the doctor therefore gave her medicine and, as a result of the pills, the temperature seemed to go down to 38 degrees.

She became not so well again on the Tuesday, which was the same as the previous day and she could not get out of bed. I again went to the doctor to seek advice and I saw her condition as very serious and he said "Well, we will see tomorrow, Wednesday." I asked him what I should do; perhaps to call a specialist. As I was not too busy my wife, may she rest in peace, told me to go and do my business and I went with my merchandise at 3 o'clock, returning at 6 o'clock and when I came to the lane that lead to the house, Haya came running towards me shouting "Mother gave birth to a son", and she was running to the chemist. I got such a shock as though a bomb had exploded on me. I ran home and everybody greeted me with one voice - Mazal Toy - but I felt in my heart that there was somethingvery wrong as I knew that it was only the eighth month

I therefore called the doctor immediately, from Hadera, and he wanted four pounds for this kind of work, definitely not less than four pounds, so I said that "You are happy but I am not", but he said that it does not matter. Anyhow, Jonah was born on Wednesday, in the afternoon of the first day of Rosh Chodesh Tamuz, Tarpad (5 684) which seems to have been a leap year.

The neighbours called the same doctor but unfortunately he was the messenger of the devil for her. I gave him one pound and arranged to pay him the odd three pounds and I was left alone with her and I saw how seriously ill she was. I called him twice again, the same doctor, and he just simply brushed it aside as if there was nothing serious. However, I stayed at her bedside all night and in the morning I saw again that it was no good.

I therefore went to visit the Hadassah Hospital and from there they sent me to Jaffa to some other midwife to call them to my house and she came, at 2 p.m. in the afternoon on the same day. Then I realised what it was to be a stranger in a foreign land with no relatives and no acquaintances, because had I been among an established family they would probably have already called a more experienced doctor, or two doctors, and not simply left it as they did. Anyway, this midwife advised that she be taken to the hospital, and she would go ahead to arrange for her admission. I followed and she was not there and there was nobody with whom to talk, and at home I had such an ill person left by herself with a newborn baby and many small children.

I returned home. I began to notice that she began to say things which were not coherent. I realised the extent of the of danger she was in and it fell on me to try and deal with small children. She had simply lost total contact with the child of one day old

the other children. This dragged on to the Thursday, right through the night, and in the morning I ran again to the midwife; she came and took my wife to the Hadassah Hospital; it was 3 in the afternoon. Two stretcher- bearers came to fetch her.

From that morning she seemed a little improved because she spoke to us and she taught us how to prepare for the Sabbath, and then I went with her to the hospital. When they admitted her they instructed me to leave immediately and she, may she rest in peace, told me "Take everything home - don't leave anything here" and these were her last words.

Saturday morning early I went to see what was going on and nobody allowed me to go into the hospital. Visiting hours were only on Mondays and Thursdays. I asked one of the sisters what was happening. She went to investigate and she immediately returned saying that I could go in and this was obviously a bombshell to me as this indicated to me that the matter was extremely grave.

I walked up to the second floor and one could clearly see that she was deteriorating rapidly and on the Sunday morning she died. That was the 4th day of the month of Tamuz, Tarpad, exactly one month since she arrived in Palestine.

The child was left in the hospital and after 18 days he had his brith in the hospital, and the Zandick was Rabbi Dvirshan and the child's name was after his mother, Taube, which in Hebrew is Jonah, may he live till 120 years.

From now on the problems really began. I was left alone with six small children who were really very small, in a new world without family, without acquaintance and without a basis of earning, and without anyone to guide me and I did not even know in which world I was. After five weeksthey sent the small child, Jonah, back and Moshe also became ill as he had no supervision that a child of two needs. In one word, I looked after the children and they looked after me and even Zehavah who was the eldest and did not even have an idea how to dress properly, took on the role of housekeeper.

In circumstances like these, thoughts even entered my mind that death is better than life. Such was my imagination, and I could not believe what had happened to me, such a calamitous tragedy that had drawn me almost to insanity and only the knowledge of leaving small, pitiful orphans kept me going. When I looked at them, I found the strength, as though Heaven had influenced me to be more positive in my outlook. I realised that there was only one way - to continue life and to re-strengthen myself, even if it were only for the orphans, and to bring them up with strength and determination and to overcome the inactive thoughts.

However, I just could not possibly forget, even for one minute, this great and terrible tragedy and on top of which I was not even busy and therefore I realised that

there was only one way and that was to get involved in business, and because I already had a piece of land I still had some money to build a house for myself because the house that I rented for three pounds a month had only two small rooms and now the landlord asked me for three and a half or four pounds. I therefore decided to build on my stand and, with the advice of the neighbour where my stand was, to build only two rooms, not from cement but from blocks, which would cost me seventy-five pounds. I began to enquire from various builders about building material until I finally arranged with a fellow by the name of Bar-Levi that he would give me all the building materials on credit and with the little money that I gave him, I made a contract at the Municipality in Tel Aviv for two rooms. Somebody then came and advised me that two rooms is silly - it would cost me another twenty-five pounds and I would have three rooms, and I realised that he was absolutely right and somebody else came and I began to consult him and then another person came and said "How come that you are building a house without cement - it is so stupid!" He said For another ten pounds you can build a foundation from cement on solid ground" and I agreed that he, also, was right and in the end I made a plan to make three rooms with all the conveniences, with a little bit more money, and I would then have a decent house and not a makeshift one.

I was busy from morning till evening with the builder and also with the business that I sold and that, at least, was like medicine to forget about this tragedy that I suffered, and despite all this I gave Jonah to a wet nurse, a Yemenite. He was with her one month and I noticed that as a result of neglect, the flies had a good meal with him. She treated him in the same manner as she treated her donkeys or sheep. The whole day he lay on the ground in the sand, the same way as the Arabs bring up their children, and as a result of that I called for my mother from Warsaw with a special request from the Government, and after a month I gave Jonah to another wet nurse but this time an Ashkenazi, a clean woman like one of us, for four pounds per month.

In the meantime the house was being completed and I saw that I had three rooms and I still had plenty of material left as well as a bit of money as I had not been sure what the whole lot would cost me, so I decided to build two rooms so that I could perhaps let it out, and in the end I made five rooms with a kitchen and all the conveniences without a preplan. Suddenly the Municipality got to know about it and I was in for a very stiff fine, and also for a jail sentence. Anyhow, the engineer managed to finish the business without a fine and without too much trouble, and after Succoth, the year Tarpah, the building was finished and my mother came from Poland.

I leased two of the rooms and I was living in the other three rooms. For the two

rooms I got a rental of four and a half pounds per month and that was very cheap, because the normal rental for one room alone was six pounds, and as the building cost me, without the land, three hundred pounds or slightly more, I became indebted to a few people besides Bar-Levi for approximately fifty pounds, for various contractors and workers. I was not able to get this money because what good stock I had, I could not sell, and there was approximately one hundred pounds of extra stock left which I could not sell in a hurry like I did at the beginning when I had marketable, good stock. All the contractors started complaining and shouting and, unfortunately, there was no way I could pay. I did not even have money for food because business was completely finished.

I only had the house now and it appeared that I was getting into more serious problems than before as my money ran out. The whole situation therefore seemed bleak and dark and I could not even pay the four pounds a month to the wet nurse. My mother took Jonah home and I then hired one room for three pounds a month, and the children and I remained in one room and a big kitchen.

The contractor, Bar-Levi, now also began with his summonses and letters of demand. I saw no way out other than to sell the house for five hundred pounds. Eventually I got seven hundred pounds for it in cash, and in the month of Shvat I sold the house and paid all my debts and was left with six hundred pounds in cash, and had to leave the house within two months.

The week before Pesach I bought a new piece of land in the centre of town for two hundred and seventy-five pounds, and spent another twelve pounds for the contracts. There was no water, no road, only a bare piece of land.

There were apparently plans to build six shops with a storehouse, and again I had to spend thirty pounds for various building materials. I was given a permit to build it and to have a dwelling place. Anyhow, there was a judgement against me and I had to pay approximately half a pound fine. As it happened, my brother came and he helped me, and in the same Pesach eve we came to the bank.

I, with my business, was the first in this whole, new shopping centre which stretched as far as the station. There was not even a sign of any settlement, but this particular Pesach brought an amazing amount of Jewish tourists from all over the world, as well as many acquaintances and friends of mine from Warsaw and other lands, and I had a great number of prospective buyers for my piece of land. They were even prepared to pay four hundred pounds or more, but I thought to myself what would I do without a piece of land but I still thought maybe I should sell and buy like before, another stand.

I ran again to the land dealers and I bought another stand next to the other stand from a person by the name of Lubichecki. 1 did not even have time to see anything in case I would not get it because there were so many buyers, more than available stands and when I went during Pesach to see where the stand is I became bleak and bitter to buy a stand without seeing where it is. However, I gave him one hundred and fifty pounds, a third of the money, and the other two-thirds to pay over a year but I also did not sell the original one and therefore I was very sorry that I acted so hastily because I had no money now to build anything, and with the help of a lawyer to whom I gave two pounds he gave me back, after much shouting and fighting, my one hundred and fifty pounds but only in post-dated cheques. It cost me three pounds with the lawyer besides the five pounds I had given him before. I brought him another buyer next to my stand because this particular Jewish person voluntarily wanted to be my neighbour without seeing the stand because he said that if I could buy he was sure he did not need to look at the stand. I got ten pounds commission and therefore i had five pounds profit and I began to build a second time in the centre of the business section, Rechov Pina, a place called Nachlat Benyamin, and another street, Yelefson which still remains today.

After Pesach I decided to send Abe to the Diskin orphanage and Abe was there till after Pesach, Tartza, and his brother Nathan. After seven years in the orphanage we sent Abe with Moshe to Africa. At the same time Tel Aviv was being built up in various sections of the town, in one word, Tel Aviv was being built and material and everything else doubled and trebled in value and out of the blue the workers went on strike as they wanted more money and therefore I was not able to continue building other than the two shops. I did not find it easy to obtain the services of new workers, only from the Yeshiva Bocherim under the guidance of Mizrachi. They built me the shops but they were not the kind of builders that were experienced and therefore much of the material got lost and wasted. In the month of Elul, Tarpah, the two shops were finished and the whole cost with the stand was six hundred and forty five pounds, leaving me with a debt of two hundred and forty pounds and I did not understand it because according to my calculations it should have been six hundred pounds.

In the middle of summer my father came from Warsaw and he hired one of the rooms for three pounds a month, and when my house was finished he came to stay with me. We lived together and we had one shop. The other shop we let for five months for twelve pounds five shillings. That means two pounds five shillings per month. I started making arrangements to sell this as we had no other business except to, perhaps, concentrate on building. I asked for one thousand pounds and I had an offer of eight hundred pounds according to his calculations so I decided that I would not take less than

nine hundred pounds. I decided in my heart to wait because I had good experience from my previous house where I got much more than originally asked and therefore I decided to wait.

Winter came in the year Tarpay. There was no income. I did not do anything so I decided once again to look for a buyer. The agents offered me seven hundred pounds and with my debts I once again decided I must sell, even though I would not get more than seven hundred pounds. I therefore decided to wait till Pesach because the previous year we had a tremendous amount of tourists and hopefully we would have as many this Pesach and I would get a better price. But because Pesach was still far away and I was not able to wait for that time I decided to sell for seven hundred pounds. Somebody else came and he offered six hundred pounds so I had rio option but to wait and it was then that the Bank Mizrachi got judgement against me for thirty pounds that I gave a builder and I was not able to pay it and they actually issued a warrant of arrest and I was arrested for 24 hours. Who knows, I might have been imprisoned for three months according to the old Turkish law for a person who owes money for at least 91 days. But my father together with people who emmigrated from Poland went to the bank and threatened to destroy the bank and to kill the whole lot of them, shouting "Do you think he is a thief or a robber - if a debtor is not able to pay, does he deserve to be arrested? He has a house - you can take the house but don't arrest him". They immediately instructed the attorney to release me and agreed that my father would pay two pounds every month to which he agreed in writing, and I was freed. Almost immediately after this episode the municipality of Tel Aviv sought to arrest me for the building rates that I was not able to pay yet.

At that time the leftists controlled the municipality and three weeks before Pesach they sent to arrest me once again as I did not have even one shilling for Pesach, and they wanted to arrest me because of that debt and I pleaded to leave it till after Pesach and for Pesach I was given, as were many of the other immigrants from Poland who were unfortunate, matzos, meat and wine, all that is necessary for a Pesach Seder, but money I had riot, even one cent, only the house and a stand and with very anxious eyes I waited for the tourists that should come for Pesach in order to enable me to sell the shop, but this time there was no tourism for Pesach, not even one person. I asked the merchants to find me a buyer and they laughted at me - "You might get three hundred and fifty pounds". Even three hundred and fifty pounds I would have accepted and therefore it was bad and bitter from all sides not to sell because the debts were just absorbing every penny that had remained with me. There was no income and the creditors were vicious and the whole life seemed pointless. At the time I just thought of ideas and I also owed

my father about thirty pounds because during the winter he earned a little bit and he was able to lend me, especially for food for the children and a few of the small debts that he paid and he even paid the Mizarachi Bank a bit of money and I had nothing.

Then the thought entered my mind that I should leave to go overseas and to travel far away even though it was not what I wanted and the expenses I did not have. It just simply entered my mind to run away from this place that had turned out to be a hell for me, and in my thoughts I thought of perhaps travelling not far away but outside Israel and the only place was Egypt. I got a Polish passport at the Consul and after much difficulty and with the help of merchants in Jerusalem I got a visa to Egypt as a new immigrant merchant for one month, but all this cost a tremendous amount of money which I did not have. I had to sell two pillows and covers and various other household goods to meet the expenses of the passport and visas.

I had to travel a few times to Jerusalem and also for the expenses of the trip to Egypt and a little bit to leave behind for subsistance. In the month of Sivan, after Shavuot, I finished all my business and was ready to leave, but three days before I was due to leave the municipal officials came to arrest me, and in my bag I had my passport and my visa, but as it happened they arrested my father for the debt of the Mizrachi Bank and they did not know anything about the debt from the municipality, but they just demanded from him to pay the two pounds per month, confirmed in writing, and they let him go.

Anyhow, three days later I travelled to Egypt through Kantara. They asked me five pounds deposit to ensure that I would not stay there more than one month, but I only had one pound with me and I pointed out that I was travelling as a free merchant and that, of course, was a joke and they were about to send me back but among the people who had travelled with me on the train was an English Jew and I told him my terrible plight and he spoke on my behalf and he shouted at them in English and because of him they allowed me to cross the border and to continue to travel.

The same night at 10h30 I came with the train to Cairo arid I had the address of a Jewish hotel, Blum, but he was not there and he was the only one who was able to give the tickets from Cairo to Tel Aviv and so I travelled with his workers to his hotel and his workers gave me the honour as they thought I belonged to the elite.

In the morning I found I did not know the language, I had no acquaintances and I did not know what to do so I left my belongings in the hotel and I went to look for other Jews like a blind man in a strange city and in the Jewish alleys suddenly somebody came towards me like the prophet Elijah - somebody I knew. I was so happy to see him and I told him all that had happened to me, how I came and what to do, so the first thing

he did, he brought me to a shop to a person by the name of Jehudah who ran a liquor store and that was the first person I knew well, and then another acquaintance came with me to seek work for he knew all the merchants in the trade because he was in the gemstone and pearl trade as well.

He did not have much time because on the same day he was going to travel to Vienna but he pointed out to me Mr Kramer's shop and because there were buyers in the shop he advised me to go back alone and to some other people and so I did and immediately on the same day I obtained work in a shop called Ben Sarelli and he gave me 50% of that which he earned and therefore it was already better than yesterday. After one day I went back to Kramer and asked him for work and he advised me that he would let me know after a week but as it was I worked with this first one in partnership and immediately sent some of the money that was left, home and after one week began to work at Kramer's for 15 grush from all the spares of the watches and work, all kinds, whether light or heavy work I received three shillings per watch and I also began to get work from other people and after the first month I earned about fifteen pounds. I began to breathe again a little bit of fresh air, from darkness to light and I was also able to send some money home and all that due to the efforts of my friend's foreman and those that began to know me.

Then I realised that there is still life in the world and that was summer when all the wealthy people travelled from Europe to Alexandria for the summer months and they promised me that with the coming winter it would be even better. I was certainly in a happier frame of mind but the Almighty who controls the world continually says to me "Don't be too optimistic because there are plenty problems for you" because it worried me that my visa was expiring and I thought to myself to travel back for a month to go back, say, for Pesach to see my unfortunate children, the orphans.

I asked Mr Kramer to extend for me if they possbly could my visa and he was quite considerate enough to send me to the passport control office He spoke with the director to see that he could do for me and this last person gave me a three month extension and to come again and see him and that is exactly what I did. When the three months were up I went again to the director of the passport control to extend for a period longer than three months. I gave him 4 shillings and he gave me an unlimited visa to stay in Egypt.

I was extremely grateful and with the winter onset work was even more than before and the watchmakers knew of me and their fees turned out to be good. I began to live again and I made an accounting that during winter I would then have earned one hundred pounds, if not more. Then I would be able to return home and so my thoughts became more and more pleasant, but many thoughts enter one's heart but G-d's guidance

remains.

Exactly one month after I got my passport stamped to remain in Egypt for good and I was so happy from all sides and without warning I came to work and the foreman came towards me with a letter and I asked what is this and he said he does not know, I should go there as it states as soon as possible with my passport because it is vitally important. I had nothing to fear as I was not aware of having done anything wrong to anybody so I did not know what to think. I took my passport and went there arid the same official who had given me the visa for good took my passport and he deleted all the stamps and he urged me to leave Egypt. I was totally confused and asked what had happened and he said he also did not know - just leave Egypt and he asked me to come back to him after two days. He retained the passport. I went from place to place like a lunatic and after ten days I was obliged to leave Egypt and I did not know for what reason.

Finally, when I went to Jerusalem I was advised that the Egyptian consulate said that I had lied to him when I went as a merchant and I remained as an employee. I tried with letters from Mr Kramer and Jerusalem and everything was in vain. I was not able to travel back again even though I tried so hard in Jerusalem to do so. Maybe I would still be able to travel. A Mr Hymie Zwi Rotto gave me work with wages to fix and I earned one pound a time and sometimes a little more than one pound in grushim per week and every Sabbath I travelled home to Tel Aviv and after three months 1 was told that there is no way I would be able to return to Egypt and the little bit of money that I brought with me from Egypt was speedily being used up, being left only with five pounds in my pocket and I decided perhaps to travel to the capital of Syria and realised that this is not for me. I returned home the same day with fifteen shillings which I gave to my mother and I returned to Jerusalem.

What can I do now - darkness/blackness from all sides - and at a loss for ideas.

I consulted Chaim Zwi Rotto and he advised me to try and get married somebody who has money and to carry on working in my trade and this would give me a living wage in Israel and not to travel about and 1 had no other advice but where does one find a woman with money and a woman who would also, at the same time, be willing to look after children. Despite all that the shadchonim started working on me and my brother too, from Jerusalem, and introduced me to Feigel who happened to have two hundred pounds and it was not for me to do such a thing for the very fact alone that two hundred pounds was more than I owed and although I would have no debts I still had no source of income and what would I do. then. After a lot of arguments with the shadchonim and my brother with the promise that they would also give me money for a shop, my in-laws

would assist me. I decided that maybe it would be alright for me to accept the shiddach and after Purim we had the engagement, I got some money and I paid 50% of my debts and on the 33rd day of the Omer I got married and I was left with seventy pounds in my pocket.

I wanted to open a workshop on my own but Chava (my new mother-in-law) said her daughter cannot stay in a shop with a room, only a proper, acceptable house or flat with proper furniture, and when I asked what I should do about making a living she said don't worry and I thought to myself, well, maybe she is right as the shadchonim advised me that if I needed more money they would give it to me, so I did what she advised and rented a house on a monthly tenancy in a place called Mocharim in the centre of the business area and I hired this house in Gaula Street, not far from the sea and a nice flat with nice furniture and I hired a shop in the street called Nachlat Benyamin.

The summer went and I was left with no money in my pocket and now it was even worse than before because with all my troubles I now had a wife with a mother-in-law and she says money I have not got any more and you must even, with your nose, dig up the grounds to get money. Once again I thought about returning to Egypt even though it would not be in a formally acceptable way as many people travel to America, they used to buy passports from people who had died and I had nothing to lose as once again life seemed intolerable from all sides, even worse than before.

I tried to get a passport from another person for three pounds and after Succoth, the year of Tarpach, exactly in the month of Mar Chesvan, I travelled once again to Cairo and after much difficulty, although I already knew the way, I came to Cairo under an assumed name and I sent the passport back immediately. Nobody knew about this except Mr Bium and I came to Mr Kramer who immediately gave me work and once again I began a fresh life but not as before because now I had a wife and she would want to come to Join me and then I would be in the same spot I had been in before - what would happen to the orphans because my father who had the debt of thirty pounds had returned to Poland and my mother was with my brother and what would happen with my house in Tel Aviv. They would not pay the rent and sooner or later the creditors would destroy everything as it was before.

They therefore left the house in Gaulla Street and they all came to Jerusalem, including Feigel, my wife. Zehavah left her work in the factory of Rotlar as she had worked there for a long time for 12 grush a day and all of them came to Jerusalem and after one month Feigel came to Cairo and it was left for Zehavah to look after the children the whole day and she had to remain at home like an old woman.

I sent her money for the livelihood and for rent, and in Tel Aviv my house was

without supervision and Zehavah was then approximately twenty years old, a young girl who at this age should be married and I had no money at all and it was not even worth anything at that stage. My thoughts and imagination began to run riot and I had no peace. The only person who was happy was Feigel but I was very down the whole winter and so the winter passed and I had one room and I lived in this room with my wife right through winter and for Pesach I had left two pounds for a whole winter with good work in Cairo because there in winter business is brisk.

So many thoughts entered my mind; what must I do now, how can I make my life easier without children and the children have no mother or father and the woman that I took left Israel and how could I go back without a passport and to bring them back. In any case it was not for me the right to make my future in Egypt with my children and it almost drove me mad with my thoughts what would happen, what would happen. I completely lost all thoughts and ideas and what would happen to the children, what would happen to Zehavah and with my house in Tel Aviv and there was no way that I was able to have peace of mind and to have enjoyment in the present life. Iomtediately after Pesach I sent my wife back to Jerusalem despite her protestations because it was actually not good for her in the heat of the summer in Egypt as it is extremely unbearable and she had to go back to stay with the children in Jerusalem and after that they all travelled to live in my house which, at first, she did not want to do, but had no alternative, and what she and my mother-in-law did not want. They were now obliged to realise that they had to stay in the shop by themselves whereas before it would have been with me, but now she had no alternative but to stay by herself with Zehavah who got her work back in the factory. I felt a little easier because at least the house was under proper supervision and Zehavah had begun to work and was getting three pounds a month and it was possible that I would also be left with some money.

In the middle of summer I travelled to Alexandria because in Cairo things deteriorated as it was not so good during the summer time, so I sought work and at that moment in time I wondered if I should not remain in Egypt and try and get a shop and with the possiblity of Mr Rosenberg, the supervisor of Kramers, and under his supervision and with his help with work and business it could possibly turn out to be good. My intention was simply to work and earn a few pounds and return to Israel because I did not come from Warsaw to Israel in order to settle in Egypt where there is no Sabbath and no holy day and after all that, what would happen to the children, and work like I had with Kramer I did not get, so I decided to return to Cairo having in my heart to try once again to obtain a passport because in Cairo I could not do it and after two weeks in Alexandria and after much difficulty and great fear I decided to try and get

a passport. not necessarily in my true name.

I immediately returned to Cairo and the months of the summer with not much upliftment. Winter came which was, as usual, much better than the summer, and it was even better than the previous winter because in the year Tarpat I remained with 70 pounds together with working tools that I purchased for about 8 pounds togther with the expenses and clothing etc. ever after sending money home, so I had it a little easier. However Feigel and her family were up in arms because during the whole winter she wanted to come back to me in Cairo and I discouraged it and I am totally against it and I hoped that if she did come I would leave Cairo, and so the winter passed till Pesach Tarpat when I returned to Israel and I left Egypt at night in Chol Hamoed to meet with my mother and brother and they persuaded me to see the family of Feigel, to go to their house. I spent three hours and the whole time they could do nothing but reprimand me without even offering me a cup of tea. Chava, my mother-in-law, and Esther, my sister-in-law, so I just got up and left as it appeared to me that they were intent on forcing a divorce on me and Feigel which obviously would have suited me well, but before when I returned from Egypt and I saw that she does supervise the children and look after them, the small children and the big children, and they are looking to her as a mother, I thought to myself i cannot do such a thing to break up her relationship with the children, so therefore what could I do to earn a living? Feigel said if 1 do return to Egypt she would also come with me. "If you don't, as it is, I will not remain with the children any more and my brother, Moshe, and my mother asked me not to return to Egypt because everybody is living here. You have a hit of money - open a shop, because if you leave again what will happen to the children, and Zehava has to get married."

So much was being said to influence me that I accepted their advice and I hired a shop in Jerusalem and immediately after Shavuot I got a shop in St Pauls Street in Jerusalem, opposite the jail, and I also hired a flat. I brought my belongings from Tel Aviv and it was my thought of finally settling in Jerusalem.

I managed to earn about one pound a week and slowly I ate up what I had saved in Egypt and because of that once again the shop and everything seemed to have gone on my nerves and again I began to think in terms of leaving but where, and in Egypt my temporary passport expired, so I thought maybe Africa.

Then I decided to become an Israeli citizen and to travel with an English passport, and perhaps with an English passport I would possibly have been able to go to Egypt again and open my own shop because, gradually, the merchants began to know that I was an efficient watchmaker but as it happened, at the same time the pogrom and riots started in Israel (1929) and these carried on until Succoth.

I did not earn even enough for rent in the shop, one pound rent for the shop a month, and I was once again without money and without work and therefore I had no alternative but to continue to travel to South Africa. I wrote to a Mr Centner that he should send me a request to be employed and all there was for me to do was to sell my house and after two months with the officials (red tape) and the whole week in Tel Aviv and so after the festival of Succoth I immediately left the shop, sold my house for 300 pounds and after all my debts to the municipality of Tel Aviv and all the other expenses I was left with 245 pounds and with the desire to help Zehava get married. I promised to give her 100 pounds when I sold my house and when I sold, Chava, my mother-in-law, told me not to give anything because what will be left for her if I gave everything to Zehava and I also needed a lot of money for travelling expenses. I decided in my heart to assist with the wedding and the dowry I would send from South Africa. The bride-groom and his parents asked us simply to make the wedding. I had no choice and I just had to accept. Anyhow, my thoughts were jumping up and down and the same was with my future machatonim and after I travelled to Africa they thought that I must be worth not hundreds but thousands and they agreed to the wedding and in the month of Shvat, Rosh Chodesh, on the 5th of the month, Zehava married her husband, till 120 years, and the month of Shvat, Taraz, in the good hour.

In the month of Adar, on the eve of Purim, I embarked on the ship Trieste on the way to Africa with the thought of travelling through Switzerland, Paris and London to rest in London till after Pesach, and perhaps act as a Meshulach for the Yeshiva Sharei Shamaim, that is in the old city of Jerusalem. They gave me a letter of recommendation to the Rabbonim in London with an accounting book that people would realise that I was travelling as a Meshulach for then I would not have to work in the interim and to do this kind of work perhaps for a year or two and possibly I would be left with a few pounds and then, hopefully, I would return to Israel with a bit of money.

One's imagination does its own tricks and time does its own work. I heard in Jerusalem that in Africa a law came out of a quota and I never gave it a thought because I thought that with an English passport I would have no problem and on the ship I heard that another lady is also travelling who is trying to reach South Africa before the quota is implemented and I also laughed at this and after some four days we came to Trieste. On Monday morning I disembarked from the ship to the address that I had with me and I travelled to a hotel called Yehuda because I had to get an English visa to London and a French visa and the Jewish owner of the hotel came with me to the English consulate and he told me I did not need a visa with the passport that I had and therefore that was OK, but I had need of a French visa and that I got. On my third day in the evening I left

Trieste and I continued my journey to Paris and in the evening at 6 p.m. I came to Venice and I disembarked as the train did not continue its journey to ny destination. That was not entirely to my liking as I had to waste six hours and 1 saw the sunset and at midnight the train came that I had to continue on my own journey and I travelled for another six hours and here I had to change trains to the train that goes straight to Paris and this I did without a language and without understanding what they were talking about because it was my intention to disembark in Switzerland for a week to try and get to know the watchmaking factories; perhaps it would help me. Eventually at 9 a.m. I reached Switzerland, but I did not know where I was or in what city I was and where to go and I was also extremely tired from all the parcels I was carrying as they were very heavy. I gave up the idea of stopping in Switzerland and I carried on and at 10 p.m. on my watch, I reached Paris where it was then 12 o'clock (Time zones) I came to Paris and I took a cab to the address that I had in my pocket and he brought me to Yehuda, a Pole who had a restaurant in Paris. In the morning I found myself in a totally new world without language and without any acquaintances.

I went to seek Kalman Rootstein and I travelled underground and above ground and after three hours being lost in a big city with almost blackened fear I came to his children that I recognised from my youth and I had not seen them for more than twenty years, but I did not find Rootstein. On the second day I saw a person in the cafe who was a watchmaker and a jeweller, and he sent me to the English consulate for an English visa. They promised to give me a visa only after I had a travelling ticket and they would allow me to go through London and therefore I had no alternative but to buy a ticket to Africa.

I planned to be after Sabbath in Paris and on Monday to travel to London because the shipping line told me to return after three days and that would be Friday. Therefore when 1 returned on Monday they would give me a ticket and on Sabbath eve Mr Kalman Rootstein did come to me and that made me so happy. I was with him till Monday as I stayed with him for two nights and I boarded with him and on Monday he came with me to the shipping office for the ticket and I got information that in third class there were no tickets because they were all sold because everybody wanted to go to Africa to try to go there before the quota was implemented.

I could get only a second class and there were still some tickets available for 60 pounds and we had to put a further deposit of 60 pounds and if I had 120 pounds I would be able to travel, and if I did not have I would not be able to travel and therefore he came with me to all the offices of shipping lines in Paris during the week to find a way as I only had fifty pounds, and there was no room in any other class and everything

seemed to have been in vain except to return to Israel but Mr Kalman Rootstein advised me to go through the East for another 35 pounds and to travel second class and also examined that possibility because I thought they would not ask me for another 35 pounds for a deposit as I only had 50 pounds in my pocket as I said earlier, so I worked in a watch factory that manufactured new watches for a few days and four days after I sent my telegram, to my surprise, I received 35 pounds that I asked for and that was a good sign. I met a person by the name of Ben Yehuda from Israel and he came with me, instead of Kalman Rootstein, to this office which was on Thursday to buy the ticket in second class and I had the 35 pounds deposit because I got a positive answer, but they had to write to London to prepare for a place me and 1 was obliged to wait till Monday to receive the ticket.

Monday morning I received an answer that the ticket would cost 57 pounds and besides this a few pounds deposit that I had, but I only had 82 pounds with me and I needed a minimum of 157 pounds besides small disbursement money. I therefore decided perhaps not to travel to Africa and finished with everything and to begin to plan a totally new strategy, so I decided to stay in Paris in the meantime for a few months but start working in my new trade and after a short while we would see what would happen. As my visa was only for 14 days I had to now seek a permit from the Government for three months.

Mr Kalman Rootstein came with me to another person who was the boss of a leather factory that makes women's coats etc. in order to see if we could obtain his assistance to obtain a permit that I needed to remain in Paris. He thought about it and he told me that you could still travel and that as long as there is life one does not have to be disappointed. I did not quite listen to what he had to say because in the next two days the last ship would sail before the quota therefore, I had nothing to think about except to travel even though I did not have much money and he was continuing to jabber away and he continued to say I must not he anxious. "I will give you another name, Freusd, also a principal of a factory of leather with a big shop, and you tell him your problem and also confer with him and help him if it is necessary." Mr Rootstein also, after the problem, turned around to me and said "Let us try, perhaps with a last attempt", so we went to Mr Freusd and when he heard the problem he immediately ordered a telephone call to the office of the immigration, and after a couple of discussions, as I understood it, he turned around and told me to be there at 9 o'clock at the immigration office and there they would see what they could do for me.

I said to myself "This is just a vain hope", because I had been there a few times and nothing had happened, so Mr Rootstein said that he would go there with me. Otherwise

there was no object in my going there by myself, and he agreed to come with me and I was also happy to go with him. We went home because it was already evening. I did not pay the required attention to what was said because time was short and there was still much work to be done so I was full of despondency because the ship was gong to leave England on Friday and I had to be there not less than one day before the ship left. That is, I had to be there on Thursday and from Paris to London I thought was a whole day travel. That meant I had to leave Paris on Wednesday and today was already Monday in the afternoon and we had still to prepare the ticket in London which also took a day, and here they were only saying they would try, but as it happened I had nothing to lose and on Tuesday morning I was in this immigration office and Mr Freusd came with his wife in a motor car.

Immediately the senior person of the immigration office received us, obviously in honour of Mr Freusd, because with him I would have to net a number and wait at least till 1 p.m. in the after- noon and when the senior person, Mr Greenberg, saw us, he opened his door and said "What does he want - he has been here a few times and unfortunately we are unable to help him with funds", so Mr Freusd, after a few words that I did not understand as it was in French, said to him that he would be responsible for the money and not to put pressure on this man who is stuck in the middle of a road, and after a bit of further discussion between them, this Mr Greenberg turned around to me and said "Go there" and gave me an address in my hand.

I told him if he is not able to help me with anything then tell me and don't send me on a wild goose chase because I already know the problem - go and come back - and even Mr Freusd who was next to me said "OK, I will give you a letter to the person whose name is Or Kreiner and i will also ask him to do everything that is in his power for you, and that is what I can do for you". He saw that I did not believe it and said "Go and you will see, you will be successful" so I thought to myself "Well, I'll go again – what have I got to lose". I took the letter with the address and after one hour's travel underground and changing trains a number of times and asking in a foreign tongue the road, I came to this place and nobody could go there. Only when they took my letter, after a few minutes did I suddenly find myself in front of an elderly, honourable man with kind eyes and 1 told him the whole story. He got up from his chair without a word, went into another room and after ten minutes returned with the following words "OK, tomorrow you will travel to London as I have now telephonically ordered you a ticket for the ship. Come to me tomorrow morning and get the tickets and go on your way peacefully and the ticket that they said would cost you 55 pounds will only cost you 47 pounds." I was bewildered and I could not believe what I was hearing. Maybe I was in

the middle of a nightmare and when he saw how bewildered and astounded I was he gave me a smiling face with a little laughter on his lips and gave me his hand and said "Don't worry, go in peace, everything will be in order".

I left him, obviously with tremendous appreciation and the second person asked me to go after lunch with Mr Freusd to take on a guarantee of 65 pounds. I fixed everything up and on Wednesday, at 8 O'clock in the evening, Mr Rootstein travelled to accompany me to the train and he also gave me one thousand Franks which was about eight pounds, and at 9 O'clock I left the city of Paris by train after exactly twenty days and much anxiety and toil that I had to suffer with sleeping in various hotels and various beds and also a lot more troubles and after much despondency.

I reached London at 5 a.m. in the morning on Thursday and during the whole day I organised my travel and I communicated with Jerusalem and Cape Town about Mr Centner and on Friday, the eve of Pesach, the year Taratz, at 4 p.m. in the afternoon, the ship, the Edinburgh Castle, left the shores of Southhampton.

Besides the other passengers, we were approximately 400 Jews on the ship, a lot from Lithuania, men, women and children, who were in a hurry to get to Africa before the quota came into effect and I was one of those. Goring the Sabbath we had a very unfortunate bit of news when a young man of 18 years old died during the night. He was already ill although he had a first Pesach day because Saturday was erev Pesach.

We started getting the matzos and wine ready and we also got special meat for ourselves and before the Seder we arranged for the funeral and the special Hesped and after completing all these arrangements they threw him overboard into the sea and obviously the minutes passed in a very strange feeling and after that we prepared the Seder with four cups of wine and a17 the Jewish travellers came to see the Seder. It was very nice but my own Seder brought up memories of generations because this Seder was arranged for us in one place where they gave us special tables on which to celebrate the Seder and for the rest of the days we ate on these tables. We ate all our meals there and also those that even ate chometz, and also other food was available, more than enough, and that was all on one table. However, the Pesach was very memorable and after sixteen and a half days on the ship to Cape Town, on Monday morning at 5 a.m., with sunrise, we reached the shores.

Everyone appeared to have had acquaintances or family and everybody was so happy to see those that were waiting for them; acquaintances who laughed and smiled and cried from joy and I am not happy nor smiling nor crying because I had no acquaintances nor family and I had no-one to turn to. It was like the sun fell from the skies and I am a total stranger in this land and after a short while my eyes caught among

the waiting crowds, Mr Centner, and now at least I also found someone I knew among the people, and at 8 o'clock the authorities, according to the law, allowed us to disembark and those that had arrived and all those that did not have family or acquaintance had to sign a guarantee of 100 pounds for two years and then everybody was allowed to go free except for ten people, and I was one of them, as we did not have anybody who could sign for us for 100 pounds, but although these ten people had acquaintances but they did not come to meet them as they lived far and I was in the same boat, so we had to sleep on the ship that was returning in a few days back to Europe, ano we had to leave the ship in which we arrived and I was bitter and heartsore, but it appeared that Mr Centner, bless him, could not rest as I had a letter for him from Jerusalem, from Mr Goldberg, and asked him if he could not go and make arrangements to avoid my having to return in the hope that he would give a guarantee for me and after many attempts by Mr Centner he was able to get me off the ship together with Mr Goldberg and on Tuesday, at 11 o'clock, I left the shores a free man and they brought me to a hotel unknown to me and the month of Iyar, Tartzah, on Wednesday i hired an office in some business in Longmarket Street. I went once with Mr Goldberg and once with Mr Centner to seek work and on Friday, the second day of month of May, I got work from Mister Elzner.

I began to work and I was quite content. I was very joyous from this situation because the first month of work I earned 25 pounds. I hoped to try and get a better shop which would be better than this one and ; began to make arrangements with my son and my family to join me. I sent papers for my wife and my son to organise it according to the rules and laws for them to come here so that we can be together and after three months I rented an office for 3 pounds and I began to get work from other people, and many Americans came to me and I was the workshop, and this kinc of work in many types of watches and wrist watches and I got work from all and sundry.

I thought to myself at first, if I can perhaps earn 40 to 50 pounds a month that would only come about in the month of December or January to April, and I was virtually earning about 40 pounds a month and after about April work seemed to have ceased and the month started deteriorating but I did get permission to bring my household to South Africa and I have only 50 pounds left that I managed to save from the whole year over and above that which I sent home and my expenses, and now it is the month of Iyar, Tartzah. Work was becoming scarce and there were times when I had no work at all, so now I worried that my wife will be coming with my son Abraham as he is also experienced in jewellery work and watches, but what will he do when he comes and how will he come. I don't even have money for expenses and besides the

expense money I would need 70 pounds for them as the guarantee when they leave the ship. All this I did not know what will the day bring?

On Tuesday, the Parsha of Vayeshev, I became a grandfather because Zehava, my daughter, had her first son. On the 6th day of Parva, Tartzah, I received a telegram from Jerusalem that on the 21st day of the month of Kislev my eldest daughter had her first child, and they named him after my first father-in-law whose name was Nathan, till 120 years old, and in the same day my father returned from Poland to Israel in the month of Sivan.

I borrowed from the Gemillas Chesed (Benevolent Society) 50 pounds with three sureties, Chamus, Kleinman and Morrison, to enable me to buy two tickets on the Union Castle for 48 pounds. Each ticket cost 24 pounds and to send 25 pounds for expenses till Southhampton and the 70 pounds was borrowed as additional funds in the event that they sent them back. I saw from the letters from my mother-in-law, Chava, that she is happy with the work my daughter Chaia did and she was keen that she remain there like a maidservant. I sent a telegram in this manner "Chaia must have office work, not housework and maidservants work, otherwise Feigel will not come"

Because they asked me, in the Union Castle Line, besides the 48 pounds and some 70 pounds, another 30 pounds for expenses from Jaffa to London, I sent home all the money, that is to say, 141 pounds, on the 27th of the month of Sivan, Tartzah.

Work diminished considerably and the position became worse from one week to the other. I began to be very sorry about their coming here, that is Feigel and Avraham, and I was about to cancel the trip with a telegram, but I did not delay the trip because the money was already with them and that meant that I did a very silly thing. It seemed that had I sent the money off and they obviously would not even listen to me and, even if they did not travel the money would in any case go to waste and I was almost at my wits end as there was a big recession in all businesses and I had absolutely no income.

From the 1st August in the month of Menachem Av I was changing offices and was going into a big office in partnership in the hope that people would come to this area and possibly this would enable me to earn better, and also the rent was only 2 pounds a month and that was at the beginning of the year Tartzah. My wife Feigel and my sons, Abe and Morris, came in the month Elul in the ship Warwick Castle through London and I was full of regret that they were coming as the times were extremely bad in my work and in all the shops there was no work. I had been losing money as the shop brought me no income, even the shop that gave me work stopped giving we work as they employed somebody full time. Avraham also had no work and so my position was shaky and I did not know what had happened to me and what would I do with them

coming. I could not even see from which place my help would come because my expenses here would go up and I would also have to send money to Jerusalem, at least 2 pounds a week as before, but I had no income, not even half of what I had the previous year, and so 1 ended the year Tartzah.

The year Tartzav, the days were a little better. Abe worked for two months - I did not know how much he earned per month. He stopped working before the Christian holidays as I expected. It was no good, not with me and not amongst the jewellers because all the other watchmakers did have a bit of work but not much, but much more than I had and I could now understand why. In the month of Kislev when Abe did work they paid him 8 pounds but at the same time they retrenched other jewellers.

Anyhow, we arranged for some sort of partnership and they worked with me in the office and they paid me 50% of the takings and Abe also gave me one pound a week for his board and that is the way I earned five pounds a month and I had money to send to Jerusalem. Even with this little that i earned I managed, and so the summer passed by in a reasonable way and later the so-called partners (sublet contractors) left and only Abe remained with me and he earned as before and he continued giving me five pounds, and which I could earn before I did not earn now. I saw that i had to just drag on with my work as I needed at least twenty pounds, but I only earned fourteen and a half pounds a month and sometimes even less. However, by the time Pesach came I did manage to pay my debts and I did not owe any money and now it remained that I should rent a house and so on but nevertheless the position was extremely grave and I began to think in terms of leaving my trade and to work for some charitable organisation in Jerusalem in Cape Town, but where does one get this kind of work and if I did get the work, am I really the kind of person to do this kind of work.

I spoke a lot with Mr Gershatnikoren and he too thought that I might have better luck because in my heart of hearts I always wanted to return to Israel and Feigel also is anxious to go back to Israel and she also is regretting coming to South Africa, but how can we achieve that as I do not earn and time was passing and the recesson is beginning.

I lost all ability to think and have plans. There is no hope and it all became black and dark and I could not see any light in these weeks. I decided to speak to Rabbi Mirvish in Cape Town and he also could not give me any guidelines or advice so after Pesach I decided to become a meshulach for a children's home in Jerusalem - what else could I do, with my wife and my sons Morris and Abraham here, but Abe could at least travel to Johannesburg and he could plan for himself because I could not do anything for him in this hour. In any case he was not yet able to stand on his own feet so it was better for him to be in another city as a stranger, then he would at least have the experience of

life with the troubles that go with it, then he would understand to be a father and he might change his ways.

Therefore I had no way to worry any more about him, but Feigel and Moshe were like two children - what to do? I sought ways to send them back home but this, too, I was not able to achieve as expenses would be between 60 and 70 pounds and there was no way I could save this kind of money in this terrible recession in this town, especially in Cape Town, and there were a lot of meshulochim in any case here and also Mr Frankel came for the festival of Pesach with a lot of letters from Ray Cook but nothing could be done for them and there was absolutely no guidance or advice we could get from them until a new idea struck me.

I will send Morris to the orphanage in Cape Town and Feigel will remain for a few months with me until I collect enough money so that they can return to Israel. I now had the problem of whether they would accept Morris at the orphanage for about three months. I knocked on everybody's door to no avail. The furniture etc. that I bought in the month of February for my new home that I hired for 5 pounds a month, I sold for the same money that I purchased it, ten pounds, and I gave to Feigel about nine pounds and i was left with about ten pounds and on Sunday, 22 May, at night I left Cape Town via De Aar, a small town in Africa, in the hope that they would take Morris into the orphanage and Feigel hired a small flat.

Abraham was like on water, he did not have the money for expenses to Johannesbug and in De Aar I started my work as a meshulach in the month of Iyar, Tartsay. In Bloemfontein I received a letter that Morris was accepted in the orphanage in Cape Town. At Kimberley I received a letter with good wishes that Zehava had a child, a daughter, for many years, and her name was Yonah after the name Taube, and then when I started my work as a meshullach I did not know whether it was good or bad.

One night I slept in the rain outside the hotel because i came at 2 o'clock, after midnight. I knocked on the door but nobody answered. Obviously they must not have heard me, so I just put my parcel under my head and I decided to sleep on the bench outside.

After four weeks of work I came to the diggings at Kimberley and there I saw how they searched for diamonds and the life of the Jews next to the big holes, and their shanty houses, so I decided to remain there one Sabbath next to the big holes together with the dogs, in a tin house without windows and this is where I had my Sabbath in the month of June in the year Tartsay.

After three months on the road and the work extremely difficult with very little

income and a lot of expenses and the deterioration in the economic situation when nobody could approach anybody to ask for money, especially from the boers that had every excuse. "Today we did not give to the meshullach because we ourselves are not earning" even though they had hundreds and thousands and it was in my thoughts then simply to discard this kind of work and after the letter that I received from Rabbi Mirvish from Cape Town I was told by the meshullach that he hates meshullachim, especially those from Jerusalem, and it looked as though he was sorry that he allowed me to travel as the receipts came to him from Jerusalem and he will certainly not send me again.

I therefore had to find a new idea amongst all the plans and i suddenly began to have visions of old just to commit suicide. I did not hear from my son or my family so I thought "Well, perhaps I should return to Jerusalem", because this was my only hope as Africa became a land of bitterness. Four days before that I arrived in East London until all the holidays were over and to find work if it would come, after having collected for my job as a meshullach.

I tired from all the small places as none of them had conveniences or kosher food and thank G-d for Rosh Hashana - 1 did get some watchmaking work and I started to work for about three weeks between the holidays and I earned ten pounds and also work that I managed to do for Abe, and I sold his rings that he sent me in the meantime. There came to me a Mr Frankel from Durban as a meshullach that Ray Cook sent from Jerusalem to Africa for the Russian rabbis that are being brought to Israel, and he advised me to join him and he would give me a percentage of what he will manage to collect, and after a couple of hours a letter arrived from Rabbi Mirvish to Rev. Altshuler and a note for me as well to stop asking for Beit Chinnuch (Educational centre) and if I do not stop working he would put it in the newspaper, so I agreed to do so and I sent hm back a letter of authority that he gave me with all the receipts that remained with me. Also from the receipts I got from Durban because I wanted to go back to Cape Town and there stop with the work.

Now suddenly came an invitation to go to Johannesburg and w'.thout forethought on the Tuesday I left East London in 24 hours to Bloemfontein, together with Mr Frankel, and on to Johannesburg.

I found Mr Altbeker with other people that I had known and they found me work in Germiston with a watchmaking shop for seventeen pounds ten shillings a month. I asked for twenty pounds as 1 thought that the work with Mr Frankel was worth more and so a month passed by and I earned 24 pounds and Mr Altbeker also gave me with new watches.

The first day of the month of Chesvan I packed my bags to go at 9 p.m. to Messina with Mr Frankel who wanted me to go with him. However, we started quarreling because of the earning capacity of the previous month and about the expenses from East London which were about 10 pounds, that he did not want to pay me. I therefore did not continue travelling and on Monday, the second day, Mr Grossberg intervened and said he would give me 7 pounds. I decided I would take the work in Germiston for seventeen pounds ten shillings a month because Mr Frankel got on my nerves. I telephoned whether I should come and he answered me it is not necessary and therefore I was obliged to travel and to try and continue with the meshulach work. I travelled up to Messina. I was in all the odd places for about thirteen days. I finished my work and I returned to Johannesburg.

I calculated that I earned about twenty pounds and I received my share of five pounds thirteen as we discussed and that was what I was left, with after two weeks of work with all the expenses of the road, without food and sleep. I then decided to ask Mr Altbeker to search on my behalf for work.

I came and found with him an office with a Mr Heyman, the first person who wanted to give me work before. After a few words of discussion and greeting he advised me to go and work for him and I naturally agreed and on Monday morning, 13th Kislev, 12th December, Tartzag, I began working in Germiston for seventeen pounds ten shillings a month.

In Germiston I was not able to obtain a kosher home but even on Sabbath could not find that I was restful as it was my need to do, so I continued boarding and lodging in Johannesburg and every morning I travelled by train to Germiston and returned in the evening. As it happened my name began to diminish and we went off the gold standard and everything seemed to have gone into a depression and all my calculations were totally out.

First of all, in the place that I stayed I paid six pounds and also the four pounds and some shillings that I sent to Jerusalem every month. Everything went up in price and it cost me more than six pounds South African and the work and the business were no good when the boss of the place stopped givine me "sublet" (contract) work, and the person who gave me work to do stopped giving me work and on Sunday, 1 March, I was without work and I was in a very difficult position.

It was like being in the middle of water, without work, without business and it is coming near to Pesach and Feigel was alone in Cape Town and what will happen now. The position was no good.

Amongst the people I had found in Johannesburg were good ones, Mr and Mrs

Grossberg, Chazan Sheini in the Wolmarans Synagogue. I told them about my predicament and my difficult situation and they advised me afterwards that the only right way for me is to return to Israel, and somebody locally will take it upon himself to accumulate money for my expenses and I gradually accepted that idea. I did not take notice of Mrs Grossberg's advice and after I finished my work and I could not see a better idea.

I seem to have been obliged to agree with her suggestion and I calculated with them and also with Mr Frankel what they could do for me in this matter, and until Pesach nothing was done, only giving advice, and it was in my mind that they will also accumulate for Feigel the expenses but because I was here in Africa it was difficult from the legal point of view to send a wife away from her husband and therefore this did not materialise.

It entered my mind again to bring her here so that at least she would be with me and I will be with her and on the eve of Pesach she arrived. For her it was a joyous occasion because she had suffered almost for a year and my plan just simply to disappear did not materialise. I could not tolerate the thought of doing such a thing for various reasons and so the festival of Pesach passed and after Pesach Mr Grossberg and Mr Frankel began to assist me to find the funds as originally discussed, but in vain, as Mr Frankel could do nothing for me but Mr Grossberg could possibly he'.p me for one ticket. Then more troubles came with the first Chazan until I realised that I had better handle it myself and go myself to people who would be willing to help and I went from one to the other until I met Mordechai Gordon, the Gabba from the Midrash Hagodol and he took the matter in his own hands to send me home and he only worked for me and for Feigel and Moshe, but I also wanted to take Abraham back and I thought to myself to give him the last of the monies I had for a ticket.

I wrote to him in Cape Town but he was of the opinion that I should not leave Africa now and it is possible that he was quite justified in this because, if I had gone to Israel with money. I might have been able to help him in other ways if I had time to do so together with helping myself, so I left him with his own thoughts and left him to avoid returning and during the last days of this happening he wrote to me that he would like to come to Johannesburg as it appeared that in Cape Town matters were no better and I noticed that that was a change of mind and I also asked from the orphanage in Cape Town that they send Morris at their expense and Abraham tried to persuade them to do the same but to no avail, and I agreed to pay all Morris's expenses from Cape Town till Jerusalem and, according to my calculations, it came to 16 pounds 18 shillings, and to send him together with Abraham to Johannesburg.

At the beginning of the month Morris and Abe came and immediately on Monday he managed to get work, and despite that he thought of perhaps traveLing with us and therefore I had to try for him as well and whatever I tried I was not fortunate to obtain the expenses for him and I am between the anvil and the hammer. If he already wants to travel I cannot leave him behind and to wait another few months I did not have work.

The little work I did get from Katz & Lourie was already finished and he was not in a position to repair new watches, although he had other work. Besides this there were no sales and despite all that I decided in my own heart not to travel without them no matter what would happen, and despite all the problems and I stopped even being in fear, and fortunately even the fear came to nought because my luck was good because Mr Lourie invited me to work for him for a few months and to repair new watches, especially the expensive ones. He gave me a work in the nice business together with tools to enable me to do the repair work, to work from morning till evening like all his employees. I only wanted to work for five days, i.e. I didn't want to work on Shabbat and I would be earning five pounds a week, i.e. one pound a day and that saved the situation in the month of Mar Chesvan, Tartzad. I was still working and Abe also worked for some 9 pounds per month and in the matter of the travel I stopped thinking. In recent correspondence Haya wrote to me that she was agreeable to be here a few more years to accumulate some money and Nathan found a work position in Tel Aviv.

Now is the month of Kislev and I am in the meantime working and according to Mr Lourie I will be with him till the end of the festivals, that is until the end of 1933, and for that I was quite grateful, and thereafter I would make the plan to return to Israel at the end of winter for the festival of Pesach, but with all this I had no peace of mind because of the letters I got that my father is seriously ill and on the eve of Shabbath, Rosh Chodesh Adar, my father died.

In the month of Tevet Tartsad, on Tuesday, in Parsha Vayera, in the afternoon, Tartsad, I got another letter from Zehava that my daughter, Haya, has decided to marry her boss without asking anybody as I always understood that her boss is not Jewish, obviously this broke me. Maybe if I could return by plane I would not have worried and in the meantime I just suffered and just wrote her a letter and I urged her to leave him and his office immediately, and as Katz & Lourie had no intention of asking me to leave in such a hurry, although it was already holidays, I on my own was not able to leave my livelihood and go to Israel without money and all kinds of thoughts entered my mind and that also I wrote to Haya. If she obeys my request and leaves her boss I will bring her, Nathan and Jonah here to South Africa as I was totally against her relationship but who knows what the day will bring.

On Rosh Chodesh Nissan I got a letter from my son-in-law that he wants to point out that he is Jewish, that as far as he is concerned his whole life will be meaningless without Haya and his whole life depends on her and he is only living for her and he asked me just to agree, and from Haya I also received a letter in in the same vein because in him she found all that is meaningful in life and her future. After such letters I had no ways but to agree and I wrote her a letter in English as he did not know Yiddish or Hebrew and I wrote Mazal Toy and I also wrote to Chava and my brother Moshe Zwi as they were totally unaware of the position. I asked them to welcome them and arrange for an engagement and also to find out more about him and in the month of Iyar I was waiting with all my expectations to receive a letter from my brother Moshe or my mother-in-law that this shiddach is a good one as Haya has written to me, but Moshe writes nothing and Chava writes the opposite to what I expected.

In the month of Sivan, the Sabbath after Shavuot, I suddenly got four letters, and they explained that Brassard was not Jewish and I was not sure at this stage that Haya would be happy. I was not sure whether Haya would be agreeable despite the fact that he is not Jewish or if she just believes him that he is a Jew and if she had known that he was not Jewish she would have agreed.

As it is Rabbi Mordechai Gordon came from his holiday that he had in Muizenberg for six months and he saw me that I had not yet left. He has also obtained and he also wanted to deposit the monies that he collected for my expenses and as it happened I had four days holiday this month and the festival of Shavuot turned out to be three days together with the public holidays and therefore I did not work. They did not even want to give me work to take home, they simply paid me for the days I had come to work, that is four days less at the rate of one pound per day and here I am under pressure, and I am being compelled to travel to Israel if it is still in my power to separate Haya from Brassard, I have no other option, for these three reasons only, but to travel to Israel and I had done everything in my power along that plan. I therefore sent a letter to the group that protects women to take Brassard under their control and to find out who he is and not to allow Haya a passport until I got there. It appeared that Haya did not care whether he was Jewish or not because I asked her to write to me and she did not answer and even stopped writing.

On 8 Tamuz Mr Mordechai Gordon got 76 pounds from the society and gave the society for Cook's to organise for me three places on the Italian ship that was travelling through Lourenco Marques to Port Said on 6 July, 24 Tamuz. They prepared the places and everything was OK with my passport that I gave to the Cook society, and Feigel's passport and Moshe's passport were completed on 17 July. Halfway I did not take notice

of it because I thought when we will travel I would write to Chava to try and organise there at the Government that we should not have any delay in Kantara, and despite all that I still sent Feigel's passport and Abraham's passport to Pretoria to renew it.

I received papers from the Government to complete and I returned them. The Government sent the papers direct to Jerusalem but I was not aware of it during the last week, and when they asked Cook's for the passport that they should check with Pretoria, but I was obliged therefore to delay the travel for a month and I immediately wrote to Chava and I sent her one pound that immediately the papers came to Jerusalem to do whatever they could for Immigration to renew the passport immediately. This was a small matter, as from my passport that I renewed the previous year for two years without any difficulty they had all the details, and I already had at least a three month extension because I will have enough time to attend to my fears and to request them to accept it, possibly by way of a telegram to Pretoria. I had a private telegram from Chava that they have carried out my requests and the house in which we stayed from Pesach, Tartzah, next to the family Freeman, also new immigrants from Poland because we came to go on the ship. I gave them the notice that they could let it out again from i July but now that I could not travel this month it became a little bit unpleasant both for me and for them but like all else, the month will pass and I am looking forward with keen eyes for telegrams to travel during August, and hopefully will anticipate some of the days for the year of Tartzad to be in Jerusalem.

The days passed that I hoped to get a telegram but none came and neither a letter, and I was also disappointed that I would probably not he able to travel in August and all of a sudden a letter came from Pretoria that the passport of Feigel's has been renewed. I then began immediately to prepare for the journey and in two days I managed everything and all my thoughts with South Africa in general and with Johannesburg in particular, and on the 4th day, being 2 September, 17 Av Tartzat at 7 p.m. in the afternoon we left Johannesburg by train to Lourenco Marques and on Thursday at 2 p.m. we arrived in the port of Lourenco Marques but the ship was delayed until Friday late in the afternoon and we embarked on Saturday morning on the Italian ship, Piave, through the port of Beira in Mocambique and Mombasa, Uganda and Aden, and many other interesting ports till the Suez. We travelled for five weeks and on the Saturday, the fifth Shabbat, the whole day through the Canal and at 9 p.m. on Sabbath night we left the ship at Port Said, but there was no train until Sunday morning. However, we arrived in Jerusalem on Monday morning, one week before the new year Tartzah.

My first job was to check out with Haya and with that I was pushed, till Succoth, from morning till night. I spent money for it and I lost my appetite and sleep and with

all my effort I was not able to break up the relationship with this man. I realised that there was no way I could achieve anything and to wait for the opportunity to do something hurtful and to try and destroy her thoughts from this stranger, so I made peace on the festival of Succoth with the help of Reuben and Zehava who came to us for the festival of Succoth from Tel Aviv.

After the end of Succoth, Tartzah, I made a partnership with my brother, Moshe Zwi. I gave him 100 pounds as a deposit for the profit sharing and not to disturb Nathan and his work in the garage in Tel Aviv. Morris was learning in an English school and Jonah was learning in the Alliance and in the evenings they learnt Gemorrah with a person who gives this kind of lesson.

The month of Kislev I had no peace with Haya in order to separate them. On the contrary, they thought that I was satisfied and for him he would have preferred her to stay with him in his house and it would only cost him minor expenses as she would be a good servant, and I thought that they were laughing at me and I am the fool and they are the clever ones because he agreed to everything I asked including converting to become Jewish. He said "Well, within a week" and afterwards, two weeks and after a month and he apparently seemed to have done nothing, for it appeared to me that he could not do anything because he had no money and he himself is not sure whether he is Jewish. So I decided in my heart to stop this game in my house and after two hours of talking on Sabbath Parsha Toldot with kindness and pleadings with her to leave this stranger, she got up from her chair and began to get dressed in order to leave and to go to him and to ask what he thinks and his reply. She answered that I have decided that this is how it is going to be and I will not change my mind. I got upset and I gave her a bit of a hiding and I ordered her to leave my house and pointed out that I am her father and she must leave him and if you feel you belong to him then I want to have nothing to do with you and you must leave my house, and it appeared that she chose her way.

She left and has not hitherto returned to me. I wrote to An that he most come for the previous Sabbath before the quarrel but he did not come because he got the letter a week later, and he came the Sabbath afterwards and it appeared that her luck was unfortunate as a result of that because if An had come the Sabbath before then I would not have given her a hiding. Ari told me that Brassard did have a Brith through Dr Neiman in the presence of a Rabbi and that they were being invited for a Chupah after a week and An endeavoured with all his might to make peace between us, and after all this trouble I could not get myself to do so. as they asked me to go to them to ask forgiveness from Haya and this I could not get myself to do, so I did not go to them and they did not come to me either. Ari then left on Sunday morning together with them and the bus

straight to the Hebrew congregation in Tel Aviv and they immediately got married. In the meantime this completed the chapter with Haya.

In the month of Shvat Haya came to me to make peace and 1 thought she wojid come from time to time to see me and to reconcile ourselves. i spoke to her kindly that it is important to have a home and that my house is always open for her when whe wants to come. She promised to come from time to time.

In Pesach, the year Tartzah, my partnership with my brother did not go so well. He became insolvent and I went out of the partnership and he gave me back three pounds per week in order to return the 100 pounds that I lent him together with 50 pounds extra and I also agreed to that. Morris finished the English school for the year 1934 because I got to know that it is a missionary school and he was not such a good pupil in any case. I also sent him to the Alliance school to learn bookkeeping but here he did not learn too well. He went every morning but never learnt anything. As it appeared there was no proper order, especially for a child like Morris, so it entered my mind that he should possibly learn a trade during the day and at night, perhaps, learn to study. Maybe he could get an office job. I found a position for him in the newspaper, Palestine Post, to become a telephone operator. In the beginning he was happy because of his good English but at the end they got tired of him because of his impudence and immaturity. At the end of the month they paid him 2 pounds 50 and retrenched him and I pleaded with him to leave his friends and try and learn and read what is necessary.

The only thing that attracted him was the cinema and his pals, and he began to tell lies. I began to give him hidings and to plead with him and scold him, both kindly and severely and he indicated he wanted to travel to Tel Aviv to find work there and whatever I said to him did not help. I pointed out that he would have nowhere to stay or to eat and therefore why not remain at home. "Here you have everything ready for you and you can work here" and he is insistant he wants to go to Tel Aviv. I gave him his expenses for the road to go. After a week I came with a letter and returned to Tel Aviv, that I am agreeable that Arye (my brother-in-law) will find him work and after a week he returned again. I spoke to him very severely and kindly again. This time he agreed to listen to every word I said and I immediately organised that he goes to evening classes in order to learn typing in English and in Hebrew as well as, hopefully, bookkeeping. He looked for work in some offices as he appeared to be a very good pupil this time and I and his teachers were very happy with his progress.

After two weeks I gave him money even to go to the cinema and I promised to give him once a month to go to the cinema and after a few days that I gave him money for the cinema I was told that he went again to the cinema and he did not go to the lessons.

This again led to quarrels. He asked me please to leave him alone. Let me go back to Tel Aviv and he wouldn't return home. I asked him for an explanation, what is he going to do, and to whom must I give the letter but he does not want to know, he just wants the letter. He got his letter and went away and I was not even aware of where he went for three days, where he was, until Haya said that he is boarding with some Arab and he is still there and I still, at this point, did not know the intention of the Arab. I arranged that he return home immediately.

Immediately work was found for him with a mechanic by somebody known as Stern but without pay, but it was still better than roaming around doing nothing.

The month of Av, Tartzah, I managed to find half a shop next to Mr Buchman in Jaffa Street. I paid for three months 3 pounds, 5 per month. My brother Moshe gave me 43 pounds back after the first account that I got from him, and from time to time he gave me some more money, but he did not honour his obligation to give me back 150 pounds that he promised me during the winter, and he said there is only 125 pounds that is outstanding and he only owes me 47 pounds. He gave me two post-dated cheques and to finalise payment in six weeks time, and I brought him back certain of the merchandise that he had given me as security from all the stock that they hid with me from the creditors, and I returned to him bit by bit over eight months, and all of a sudden he complains that he is missing gold watches and goblets, some 190 pieces, and also various other merchandise. Anyhow, I tried to show him that there is nothing that is missing and he must not pass rumours to anyone but he said definitely, I did get this and I did not return it to him and he is only blaming me that I stole it. if he will pay me back what he owes me he will call me to swear on oath but besides lessening my name with the creditors by being in partnership with him, he is now accusing me of being a thief, so I broke the partnership and at the same time I began my own life.

I sought all the opportunities to go to lectures from Dr Trivoni who cures without medicine and without prescriptions and without any tricks and operations. He just simply allows the body certain exercise and to enable the body to heal itself naturally which is a gift given to all living bodies and specially to man which has been affected by the Almighty, blessed be he. From the doctor's lectures that appeared to be on the right path, that meat, all other meat products were not correct for us to eat as our bodies are against eating other animals, only fruit and vegetables should be eaten for a healthy subsistance. I therefore threw all meat products away including fish, milk, cheese, butter, eggs and salt and sugar. Times were hard but I progressed and was also satisfied that I am feeling well, Thank G-d, in all my faculties.

The month is Chesvan, Tartsav, three months that i did not eat any meat products,

only fruit and vegetables and thank G-d, I was very well although I still have no living income. My shop gave me nothing, not even the rent and I am again very sorry about this and I am also again seeking advice what to do further. I have no money as I spent 300 pounds on stock and expenses of the shop and my brother, Morris, owes me.

After Succoth, my son Moshe left Stern as he did not give him one shilling so he began working at Haya, so what is the advantage of his going over to her, only time will tell.

It is Chanuka, Tartsav, and the owner of the shop sold the shop as business was very bad. I got back certain bills on the sale with 4 pounds in cash and I left the shop and the whole land is in depression, so I had no other alternative but to return to Africa and I began to prepare myself for this as I had nothing to lose - I had no home and Haya I have not seen for a whole year and Moshe is doing everything to avoid seeing me and he does not come at all, and Jonah also followed Haya and Moshe. I began to prepare for my journey.

I sold everything I had including my household goods and on 30 January, the month of Shvat, on a Thursday in Parsha Be, Tartsav, I again embarked on the ship Asperia in Haifa and I travelled through Beirut, Alexandria, Naples, Geneva, and from there I embarked on the ship Julius Caesar and on Saturday in the Parsha Mishpatim, I again disembarked in Cape Town and that night I travelled to Johannesburg where I came on the second night, and I again went to Katz & Lourie but I was not able to get work. They kept telling me they did not have any place for me and therefore Mr Altbeker gave me a place in his office to work. My intention was to bring here Nathan and Jonah for whom I have already sent papers during the month of Tamuz, Tartsav, and got from the Government the entry permit to Africa for Nathan and Jonah, and also I purchased the travel tickets and I sent these to them. They will also come in the ship Julia which leaves Haifa at the end of the month of Av in the hope that it will be before Rosh Hashana, Tartsas. There was no place in this ship because it was full with the German refugees who came to Africa in great numbers, and there was also a Great Exhibition in Johannesburg so there was no room to give them in this ship. Therefore they got place in the second ship called Julius Caesar and they eventually arrived in the month of Elul, Chol Hamoed.

I put Jonah in the orphanage in Johannesburg and we were all satisfied with this but from Nathan I had very little pleasure because at his work he had to work day and night the whole week, otherwise they would not give him work and that was also very difficult.

During the month of Elul, Tartsas, in the month of Tamus I got a cold and I got

pneumonia and I landed up in hospital. After three weeks I left, thank G-d, peacefully but I lost five weeks of work, nearly 40 pounds, and at the hospital they gave me food that I had not touched for two years and as I had nothing else to eat and therefore I got re-acquainted to eat what they gave me, meat, milk and after two years of eating only fruit and vegetables and bread and now also absolutely taken aback and did not fully appreciate which is the better food for one's health.

Nathan did not work the whole period that I was sick and I urged him to find other work even as a tailor because the depression was serious and the times were very bad in every trade and there was absolutely no work. The Union is also not allowing work and after much trying that he should perhaps go and help me to fix watches, and I took him to my place to teach him watchmaking. Thank G-d I was also appointed the shofar blower in Wolmarans Synagogue for Rosh Hashanah for 6 pounds and at this stage I was not yet sure about my teeth, they had to be extracted and make me new ones as they were causing me problems in my mouth when I used to blow the shofar.

In the month of Kislev, Tartsag, Nathan left the watchmaking business and returned to his work as a motor mechanic. Abraham started working for himself, left his employer and in the month of Adar Aleph I wrote a letter to Feigel that it is impossible to continue in this kind of life with each one for himself, and therefore there is only one way and that is to separate and get divorced, and I undertook to give her 200 pounds for this.

After my first letter my mother-in-law agreed but they wanted more money so I increased it by 5 pounds for two months living that I used to send her until now. In the month of Tamuz, Tartsag, I wrote and sent her the Get papers and 205 pounds through the Rabbis in Johannesburg and after six months, in the month of Kislev, Tarszat, I got the separation papers and in the month of Chesvan Morris came back from Israel and he began working as a jeweller with Abe. He worked for about four months but every day there were fights between them until they left each other. He did not want to return under any circumstances so I found myself helping him to find work with Mr Weinberg for ten pounds a month.

From the month of Sivan, Chavka (my mother-in-law) agreed to the "get" and I decided to get re-married. I was introduced to about fifty unmarried women and after about eight months I found my new wife, Alisa, may she rest in peace, and we at last came to an arrangement to get married on 12 Sivan, Tartzat, at the Wolmarans Street Schul, Johannesburg. We went on honeymoon to Durban for twelve days and then I moved in with her as she had a two bed-roomed flat. We then rented a five roomed flat so that Abe, Nathan, Morris, Kurt and Gerald could stay in the same flat and after i

returned from Durban, two weeks had passed and I was faced with not even one pound to contribute to the house. I borrowed from a person 2 pounds and I gave it to my wife. In the meantime she provided everything because the 50 pounds that I had and the 50 pounds that my wife had was spent for the holiday and for the flat and also for the flat utensils and we stayed in that flat for six months for 21 pounds a month and that was very difficult to pay. I paid the whole rental and from the children I only got 35 pounds a month and had to pay all the accounts and also my wife worked as a milliner and she continued with her millinery work after we got married, but how could she work if she also had to manage the house and cook for eight people and I also wanted her to come to my office.

After six months I rented another flat for 9 1/2 pounds a month and fortunately the work situation also improved very slightly and therefore I was, so to speak, safe from both sides.

Approximately one and a half years after the wedding in the month of Adar, Tarsha, I bought a house in Yeoville, no. 6 Francis Street, which people said was a "metziah" (bargain) because a house in Yeoville for 1 025 pounds was an extremely good buy. I only paid 200 pounds and even with the repairs the whole thing cost me 1 300 pounds and from my own pocket I took out approximately 250 pounds and I had to pay 10 pounds 10 shillings a month until I paid off the whole debt. I even managed to buy new household requirements because I had five rooms now and we had to have more household goods. Jonah also came to stay with us from January 1941. Nathan was in the army and Morris went to Durban. He found himself a wife but the marriage was annulled very quickly. I also bought a safe for my work and it was now Chodesh Tamuz, Tarshay.

I entered my new house in the month of Iyar and my furniture arrived and at this stage I was very satisfied. All told I spent 375 pounds and everything including the alterations cost me 1 380 pounds and now I am paying 10 1/2 pounds to the building society.

Nathan is already a year in the army as a motor mechanic in the transport division in North Africa and he is nearing Egypt. From Morris 1 have at this stage no comfort and Jonah is already at high school in form IV.

This is the month of Adar, Tarshag. Jonah finished matric and has gone to university. Nathan returned to Johannesburg from the North with the First Division.

This is now the Pesach, Tarshag. Abe got engaged and tried to make peace with us after many years of bitterness from simple, stupid matters and especially the last two years the bitterness was deep, so we made peace. The month of Tishrei, Tarshad, Abe

got married to his fiance, Esther Lampert.

I almost ceased my own work during the past year as I began to deal in diamonds and the diamond business suddenly quietened. I lost a lot in my gemstone dealings and therefore I had to continue working in the trade. During the year it improved and my work slowed down as I began to do more business in merchandise.

In the year Tarsha Jonah left university and he began to work with an accounting firm. I wanted him not to work on Sabbath and he went to another firm and he worked for other people where they did work on Saturdays and for that he left home and went to Abe. Again animosity developed between me and Abraham until Ruthie was born, the same year as the war ended.

I wrote to Switzerland for watches in order to import watches to Johannesburg, under the style Liban and also other watches from Switzerland. In the beginning it was very good as I sold them all as I imported them and also the diamond trade improved considerably. i began to deal with more watches and more watch straps from America and also about "magalliot" merchandise from Judea. At that time I had very good periods in my business life and that time, in the year Tarshav, I had an operation.

Business began to deteriorate as there was an influx of many watches and the market was flooded with watches and buyers were becoming fewer as they (the retailers) also began to import goods and it was impossible for me to compete against the big dealers (wholesalers) who would give four, six or more months credit and they also had agents to work for them who would travel all over the place including the small places to sell the goods. That was in the year Tarshach and slowly my position deteriorated and i was only left with the diamond goods and rings and it was difficult to make a living as the market contracted.

Again I had very little work and the days began to be again unpleasant and once again my thoughts were to go to Israel as I had no other choice. I was continuously pulled to the roots of Israel and in that month of Kislev

Morris was married to his fiance, Jessie Hurwitz, and that year I did not think of going to Muizenberg as I had done every year as I had no money and times were bad without earning, but I was obliged to go as my wife, may she rest in peace, was dangerously sick and so we decided in the month of Tevet to travel there and we were there for a month and thank G-d my wife came out of danger and improved considerably. When I returned from Muizenberg in the month of Adar I began to prepare myself and make arrangements for Israel and at the beginning I did not believe that I would manage but thank G-d everything went smoothly for the journey. My wife went to stay with her son, Gerald, and I let my house for 27 pounds a month as it was

difficult to sell a house and I had only 520 pounds as well as some stones for about 1 500 pounds and in the month of Yud Aleph Nissan, 3 o'clock in the morning I travelled on a Viscount to Lod for Pesach 1949.

I sold my merchandise with a very good profit. I stayed with Zehava and I did not find it comfortable to stay with her. It appeared that the whole of Israel was against Johannesburg - the scenario.

I left with Zehava all my work tools and returned after six weeks. I found my wife again very ill in Gerald's house. She was very happy to see me as she found it impossible to live by herself with them, so I stayed also at Gerald's. I sold the merchandise that I brought back with me although I had money I could not do any business and we also found staying with Gerald not comfortable and I could not repair any watches either. I had no tools as I had left them in Israel, so I saw no other avenue other than to return to Israel and I took with me whatever I could to leave Africa. I then organised a "lift" with whatever I had, also with merchandise, and everything was now ready for the journey. My wife became seriously ill again. However, she did agree to the journey but a week before the journey they stopped her from going so I was left by myself and Nathan came with me, arriving in Israel four days before Rosh Hashana, the year Tarshai 1949.

I was totally lost of ideas. My wife was very sick. Dr Neumann in Johannesburg said that he did not think she could live another two years and perhaps even less, so she went to stay with Kurt. It was my intention to buy a flat but it was impossible to pay the 3 000 pounds or more and even if I did have a flat I had no business and to buy a flat for 1 000 pounds only for key money I did not have. I was confused and the days just seemed to have vanished.

I managed to get a room for 16 pounds a month and I slowly sold my merchandise with a good profit and I again had money so I began to look for a flat, a one or one and a half roomed flat, to buy, even if it is outside the city in Bnei Brak, but there was nothing I could buy that appealed to me and after a few months on 14 November 1949 I succeeded in buying in Yarkon Street no. 147 for 3 400 pounds besides other expenses of about 200 pounds and thank G-d I was able to pay everything and I took possession on 10 December 1949.

I brought all my things from Haifa and I organised in the meantime everything myself for the flat and my wife wrote to me that she wants to come and stay here with me as she does not find it pleasant or comfortable to stay with Kurt and his wife. She is now feeling much better from the time I left her and she is willing to come to me here, but it is difficult_ for her to travel by herself and she asked me if I would not come and

fetch her to bring her back. I decided to travel.

I made all the arrangements and I was left with 600 pounds. I received from Reuven 1 400 pounds and on 12 December 1950 I left Tel Aviv and 1 had with me altogether 2 000 pounds. I gave it to somebody who will give it to me in Johannesburg but he did not give it back to we and with great difficulties I got 1 000 pounds back, and with that money I bought other necessities and paid for the tickets back and including the purchasing of other goods for about 700 South African pounds and, in the three days before Pesach, made the journey with my wife which apparently was good for her as well, but when she came here she fell seriously ill. I found a doctor and he came nearly every day. At infrequent intervals she got up from the bed. I at once got Prof. Zandak but she was seriously ill and deteriorated slowly. I suffered a great deal both day and night and felt numb and also deteriorated in health, and at the end her sister from Balfuria came to fetch her to stay with her and the two weeks was also very good for her and we were all very grateful and happy.

Suddenly in the third week that she was there, without any reason of whatever nature, apparently a horse and cart came past, we don't know how, resulting in her falling back to bed. We thought it would pass after a few days but it was the opposite. The position deteriorated daily and I was sent a telegram on Friday night in the afternoon (erev) Tish Abav and on Sunday in Tish Abav I travelled with the first bus to Balfuria. I travelled at the last minute. I found the position very serious. I ran to the doctor in Afulah and I had no option but to bring her to the Afulah hospital but it was not possible to admit her to the hospital in Afulah. so the doctor himself telephoned Tveria on Monday and organised a bed for her in the hospital. On the Monday we got an ambulance and brought her to Tveria and at 2 o'clock in the afternoon when we reached the hospital I left her and that was the last time I said "Shalom" to her and on the Thursday, 13 August, I got a cable that she died, so I again travelled to Tveria. On Friday Nathan and Zwi came for the funeral at 2 p.m. and at 4 p.m. the three of us returned to Tel Aviv and Zehava looked after me the whole week (of sitting Shiva).

For about two months I felt the bereavement and what to do and how should I react. My first reaction was to finish with South Africa and sell the house and the furniture. In the meantime I had a bit of business and I was left with some 3000 pounds so I bought a return ticket on 28 August 1950. At the last moment I was introduced to my new wife Hayala, may her soul rest in peace, so I decided to postpone the journey for two weeks and to get married and so I planned that she too comes with me. I paid for her ticket as well and I was left with 2 500 pounds worth of merchandise and on 19 November at 8 o'clock in the evening we went to the offices of El Al and two nights later we arrived in

Johannesburg and we met Abraham and Gerald.

I stayed two nights at Geralds and Haya stayed with Abe as a visitor from the family Grundland who lived in London and nobody was aware that we were married. After a few days Haya went to Cape Town and I went to stay in a hotel until the end of the month. On 22 December Morris and his family travelled to Muizenberg with their car and invited me to go with them and then I told them about Haya being my wife, and with the Germans (the family of Alice, my third wife) I could not come to a friendly arrangement, even though i gave them the furniture before I left for Muizenberg. After they got to know that I got married they thought they could demand money from me so I was obliged to go to a lawyer to arrange to give them 400 pounds to finish with the matter.

I had an operation on the prostrate gland on 11 September 1951. After nearly ten months I once again managed to get on to a plane to return to Israel to my flat as I began to feel more uncomfortable in South Africa. obviously did not earn anything and I did not have a flat. I stayed all the time with my mechuten, Hurwitz. This was against my wishes and against Haya's wishes. However, I did not know that at the time Haya was with me she was like a servant in the house.

In the meantime I set the furniture that was left in the house after I sold most of it for 2 950 pounds. This was a good sale and after all the expenses etc. and paying the demands of Alice's children and of my lawyer's expenses, I was left with 850 pounds and that was worth approximately 2 400 English pounds.

5 November 1951. The furniture that I sent to Israel 1 gave half to Haya and half to Nathan. I gave Haya a steel bed and Nathan a washing machine and other kinds of household goods. I gave them whatever I had in the house for a present and they paid me for the new things and the expenses of the container from Johannesburg, 3 Israeli pounds and one pound sterling as the Israeli pound was devalued in 1952 and the gold was also down. I purchased diamonds in order to get rid of the money and I also entered hospital for an operation and after a month I returned home and the pound improved but the merchandise, gold and diamonds, went down in price so I was left with no money and I again was approached to sell my stones with huge loss besides not earning month after month.

So once again everything felt terrible from all sides and there is no income.

In June 1952 Brassard died and after six months Haya, my daughter, went to Johannesburg in 1953; the month of May she returned. In 1954 I tried to find a husband for her but her luck was the opposite but what my wife and I wanted for her. Haya herself found a man by the name of Joseph Lifshitz, exactly the opposite of Brassard in

every way and whatever we tried to persuade her did not materialise and the whole family was against the marriage and she wanted her way and at the end, against my wishes, she married him. She had a very good business with a partner who was extremely straight and honest and faithful and he did not want Joseph to help him in this business.

In the month of Sivan, Tarshaz (1957) I had no income, just about enough for food and the money is slowly but surely getting less and less. Despite all that I had to be satisfied because everything seemed to have come right with me and I was busy from morning till night with a bit or watch fixing and household chores and the main thing, I began to interest myself in various books and general knowledge etc.

---00000---

Zehava and Reuben had a first-born by the name of Nathan.
Yonah was their second child, a daughter, and Menachem was their third son.

Abraham and Esther had Ruth, a daughter, their first born, Menachem (Manley), a son (the second), Naomi was the third, a daughter, then Sharon was the fourth child, a daughter.

To Nathan and Blume the first daughter was Chayala, Eli, the second, a son, Tovale, the third, a daughter.

Maurice and Jessie had a first son Victor, a second, a daughter, Shelley, a third, daughter Jennifer, fourth, daughter, Arlene.

Jonah and Maisie have three sons, Raymond, Trevor and Colin.

And altogether, Kein Anhorrah, I had sixteen grandchildren.

Yonah, the daughter of Zehava, on the Sabbath Parshat Korach, 23rd of the month of Sivan in the year Tarshaz (22 June 1957) gave birth to a child and his name is Aviram, the son of Eliezer Halperin. In the festival of Succoth, on Sunday, the first day in the year of Tarshach (17 October 1959) another son was born to Yonah, my granddaughter. In Simchat Torah was the Brith and his name is Noam, the son of Eliezer Halperin.

My business activities stopped. However, I had still 6 500 Israeli pounds at the bank. I had 5 500 pounds at 18% and that was enough for half a living. Chaya gave me 300 pounds a year.

Nathan, the son of Zehava, got married in the year Tarshach and in the year Tashga (one year later) the first child was born, Chagit, the eldest, from my eldest daughter, the wife of Reuven Grundland. Nathan, the eldest son with his wife Miriam and their daughter, Chagit, the eldest; Yona, the wife of Eliezer Halperin, their eldest son Aviram, the second son Noam; Menachem, the son of Zehava; Abraham and his wife Esther, Ruth, the eldest daughter, Manley, Nomi, Sharon; Haya, the wife of Joseph Lifshitz; Nathan's wife, Bluma, her first daughter Hayale, the second child, Eli, third one Tovah; Moshe and his wife Jessie, their eldest son is Victor, second one is Sheina Leah, third one is Feigel.

Jonah and Maisie had their eldest son Raphael Mendel - Raymond, second
Tuvia - Trevor, third Kalman Nissan - Colin, fourth Bezalel - Charles

On the Sabbath of Norgmud, 14 Tashchav, 1961 Nathan, my grandson, had his first child, a daughter Chagit, and the second one by the name of Meirav, Chagit's sister.

My son Jonah had a fifth child, for many years, by the name of Arya - Adrian, on 18 Tamuz, Tashkag (10 July 1963, in Johannesburg. A11 of them are in Johannesburg.

Ruth, the first born of Abe and Esther, got married to Yoram Silberman from Haifa, Lag B'Omer, Tashka (19 May 1965). Their son Ran was born on 23 Tevet, Shakaz (5 January 1967)

Nathan, son of Zehava and Reuven - a 3rd child on the 13th of the month of Nissan (1 April 1969) a son was born by the name of Boaz. Before him, of course, was Chagit who was first, Meirav was second.

Ruthi, my granddaughter, had a daughter on 16 June Tashkat, the month of Sivan on the 2nd day, and her name was Orly.

Menachem, the third son of Zehava and Reuven, got married in the month of Chesvan,

the year Tashkach, to Sarah, the daughter of Shoshana, and in Haifa they had a first child, Gila on the Saturday the Parsha of Chaya Sara, 27 Chesvan, Tashkat (8 November 1969).

Nathan, the son of Zehava and Miriam, his wife, had another daughter, Yonah, born on Wednesday, the first day of Rosh Chodesh, Tamuz Shvat, Tarpad.

---00000---

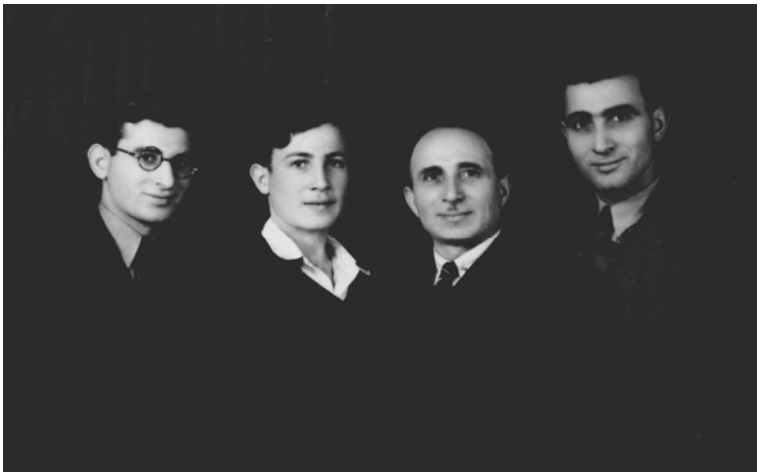
In 1969, which seems to be when the last entry was made in his memoirs, Jacob Aron Perkel was approximately 87 years old.

He died aged 93 in (1975)

Aron Jacob's first wife, Toybe Sheindel, with their children
in Poland (anti-clockwise from the top): Pinchas (who passed away at 17 months old),
Nathan, Zahavah, Abe and Chaya

Aharon Yaakov Perkel with his fourth wife, Chaya,
and Raymond (4 months) first-born child of Jonah & Maisie
Johannesburg 15 April 1951

Aron Jacob with his mother, Elke, his second wife, Feigel and his children
(back l-r) Abe, Zahava, (front l-r) Jonah , Morris.



Aron Jacob with his sons Nathan, Jonah and Abe